Holy Trinity University

For Extension and Weekend

Course Title: Mariology and the Theology of holy Cross

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Course Description:

This course presents a comprehensive theological and biblical exploration of the Holy Virgin Mary and the Holy Cross within the doctrinal framework of the Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church. It aims to examine the person, titles, and roles of the Virgin Mary in the economy of salvation, her biblical typologies, and her veneration in the Church, along with the theological, Christological, and soteriological significance of the Holy Cross. Through Scripture, Patristic writings, and liturgical teachings, students will develop a deeper understanding of Marian devotion and the mystery of the Cross as central pillars of Orthodox faith and life.

Course Introduction:

The course "Mariology and Theology of the Holy Cross" is designed to deepen students' understanding of two core components of Orthodox theology: the role of the Virgin Mary in salvation history and the theological depth of the Cross of Christ. The Virgin Mary, the New Eve and Ever-Virgin, is revealed through Scripture, tradition, and symbol as the Theotokos and a vital participant in the Incarnation. Likewise, the Holy Cross is not only the instrument of Christ's Passion but also a divine sign of redemption, restoration, and the love of God. These two themes Mary and the Cross intersect in the divine plan of salvation and offer profound insights for spiritual formation and theological reflection.

Course Objectives:

By the end of the course, students will be able to:

1. Understand and explain the biblical foundations of the Virgin Mary's role in salvation history.
2. Identify and interpret key Marian symbols and typologies (e.g., Ark of the Covenant, Burning Bush, Ladder of Jacob).
3. Analyze Patristic teachings and Church tradition concerning the veneration of the Virgin Mary.
4. Articulate the theological and salvific significance of the Holy Cross in Orthodox doctrine.

5. Evaluate the Christological, ecclesial, and symbolic dimensions of the Holy Cross.
6. Reflect theologically on the interrelationship between Mariology and the mystery of the Cross in light of the Incarnation and Redemption.

Learning Outcomes (Course Results):

Upon successful completion of this course, students will be able to:

1. Provide a theological explanation of the Virgin Mary's titles, roles, and perpetual virginity from a biblical and patristic perspective.
2. Interpret and teach on the Marian symbols as found in the Old Testament and Church tradition.
3. Appreciate the importance of Marian devotion and its expression in Orthodox liturgy and daily Christian life.
4. Explain the centrality of the Cross in Orthodox theology, worship, and salvation.
5. Demonstrate how the Holy Cross is a symbol of victory, life, and divine love, as well as the fulfillment of Old Testament types such as the Bronze Serpent and Rod of Moses.
6. Integrate Marian and Cross theology into a coherent understanding of Orthodox soteriology and Christology.

CHAPTER ONE

1. Introduction

The course "Mariology and Theology of the Holy Cross" is designed to deepen students' understanding of two core components of Orthodox theology: the role of the Virgin Mary in salvation history and the theological depth of the Cross of Christ. The Virgin Mary, the New Eve and Ever-Virgin, is revealed through Scripture, tradition, and symbol as the Theotokos and a vital participant in the Incarnation. Likewise, the Holy Cross is not only the instrument of Christ's Passion but also a divine sign of redemption, restoration, and the love of God. These two themes Mary and the Cross intersect in the divine plan of salvation and offer profound insights for spiritual formation and theological reflection.

1.1 The Virgin Mary and her early life revealed through scriptures

The Holy Virgin Mary was mystically formulated in the minds of the generation of Abraham, the children of hope who anticipated the advent of the Messiah. St. Mary was conceived in the mind of God as part of His redemptive plan. She would bear offspring powerful enough to crush the head of the serpent as predicted in Genesis 3:15, which is frequently identified as the proto evangelium - the first annunciation of the gospel. In his vision, St. John the Evangelist saw the same woman being persecuted by the serpent (Rev 12:l).As awareness grew about God's redemptive plan and people looked forward to that day more and more eagerly, prophecies referring to the glorious woman became more commonplace.

Later forecasters made clear that the woman who was destined to defeat Satan was St. Mary, the bearer of God. Seven hundred years before Christ, the prophet Isaiah proclaimed that the woman who had been anticipated by millions was about to appear:" Therefore the Lord himself shall give you a sign; Behold, a virgin shall conceive, and bear a son, and shall call his name Immanuel" (Is 7:14). Of her powerful offspring and His mission of emancipation, the same prophet added: "For thou hast broken the yoke of his burden, and the staff of his shoulder, the rod of his oppressor, as in the day of Midian....For unto us a child is born, unto us a son is given: and the government shall be upon his shoulder: and his name shall be called Wonderful, Counselor, The mighty God, The everlasting Father, The Prince of Peace" (Is. 9:4-7).

Holy Tradition says of St. Mary's parents, St. Joachim and St. Anne, that they were a couple known for their strict observance of God's law, uprightness of faith, and saintliness. However, in spite of their yearning for a child, St. Anne remained infertile for most of her life. Vowing to

dedicate their child to the service of God, they were finally given a daughter predestined to be the bearer of the awaited Messiah. On the ninth day after the birth, they summoned their family members and neighbors to the naming ceremony and gave her the name Mariam.[1]

According to Vassall-Phillips, the name Mariam means Sovereign Lady or Princessin both Greek and Latin.[2] Despite the fact that she was her parents' only child, the Holy Virgin Mary pleased St. Joachim and St. Anne in her glorious life. Solomon writes of her: "My dove, my undefiled is but one; she is the only one of her mother, she is the choice one of her that bares her. The daughters saw her, and blessed her; yea, the queens and the concubines, and they praised her. Who is she that looketh forth as the morning, fair as the moon, clear as the sun, and terrible as an army with banners?" (Song of Songs 6:9).

St. Epiphanius (315-403 AD), a well-known exponent of the Orthodox Church in the patristic period, provides a summarized account of the righteous life of the Virgin's family, her exceptional saintliness, and the glorious contributions she made to the salvation of the world. His narrative reads in part:

From the root of Jesse sprung King David and from the family of King David the holy Virgin holy I say and the daughter of holy men. Her parents were Joachim and Anne, who pleased God in their life, and bore fruit also pleasing to Him —even the holy Virgin Mary, at once the Temple and the Mother of God. These three, moreover, Joachim, Anne and Mary, offered to the Trinity a sacrifice of praise. For Joachim is interpreted the Preparation of the Lord, since it was from him that the Temple of the Lord was prepared, even the Virgin. Anne is interpreted Grace, because Joachim and Anne received grace, after having prayed, to bear such fruit, by obtaining the holy Virgin. For whilst Joachim prayed on the mountain, Anne prayed in her garden. Anne then conceived and gave birth to Heaven and the Throne of the Cherubim, the holy child Mary. For she will be found to be Heaven, a Temple and a Throne, since she, whose name of Mary we are

1 O. R, Vassall-Phillips, *The Mother of Christ or The Blessed Virgin Mary in Catholic Tradition, Theology and Devotion* (London: Bums, Oates &Washboume, 1922), pp. 5-6.
2 O. R, Vassall-Phillips, *The Mother of Christ or The Blessed Virgin Mary in Catholic Tradition, Theology and Devotion* (London: Bums, Oates &Washboume, 1922), p. 6.

wont to interpret Lady and also Hope, gave birth to the Lord—who is the Hope of the whole world—that is, to Christ. Again, this Name of Mary is interpreted Myrrh of the Sea. By myrrh may be understood—and this is my opinion—immortality, since she was to bring forth the immortal Pearl in the sea—that is, in the world. Moreover, the Virgin brought serenity and calm to the sea, that is to the whole world, by giving birth to Christ, who is a Haven of rest. The Blessed Name of the Glorious Virgin Mary is also interpreted, She who is full of light, since she was illumined by the Son of God and has enlightened all who believe in the Trinity, even to the ends of the earth.[3]

1.2 The role of Virgin Mary in the history of human salvation

Soteriologically, the life of St. Mary is most closely linked with the redemptive works of God. This is precisely because whenever we remember what God has done in the economy - Christ's miraculous virgin birth, His flight into Egypt, His public ministry. and especially His crucifixion and sacrificial death, it is impossible to separate the Mother of God from salvation history. This is mainly because she is the one who gave birth to the Savior, who is persecuted with Him during their flight in to Egypt and is associated with His public ministry and who was never departed from Him even at the last moment beneath the Holy Cross. All of these steps clearly show the vigorous involvement of St. Mary in the economy of salvation.

1.3 Biblical perspective

The Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church uses typological interpretation in its reading of the Biblical witnesses on St. Mary. In the Bible the Blessed Virgin Mary is seen to be symbolically prefigured and typologically typified with various symbols and ideals at the time of the patriarchs. She is also seen to have been revealed in manifold prophecies throughout the Old Testament. Besides, she is also mentioned openly in the New Testament especially due to her significant role in the economy of salvation. In asserting this, the Anaphora titled with her name testifies: "O Virgin, thou art the ideal and the prophecy of the prophets; the favor of the apostles, the mother of martyrs; the sister of angels.,, Nevertheless, a thorough discussion of

[3] O. R, Vassall-Phillips, *The Mother of Christ or The Blessed Virgin Mary in Catholic Tradition, Theology and Devotion* (London: Bums, Oates &Washboume, 1922), p. 6.

each and every ideal and prophecy in this limited research paper would be beyond the scope of the thesis. For that reason, it is only a couple of them are taken in to consideration due to their strong soteriological importance. Amongst her numerous ideals and symbols are the Promised Woman (i. e., the New Eve), the Ark of Noah, the Thicket of Isaac and the Ladder of Jacob. In addition, these symbols also unfold the richness and simplicity of the Mariological tradition of the Ethiopian Orthodox Church, especially in accordance to its strong relationship with soteriology.

CHAPTER TWO

2. The promised woman of the new eve

The Genesis account of the promised Woman is regarded as the forerunner of the divine plan of salvation to humanity. Thus, the prophetic foreshadowing of this woman is the very first divine hope of salvation given to Adam and Eve after their fall into sin. Thus said the Lord God, "I will put enmity between you and the woman, and between your offspring and hers; he will strike your head, and you will strike his heel" (Gen 3:15). Basically, this divine promise vividly highlights the thematic significance of the Blessed Virgin Mary, the mystery of the incarnation, and the subsequent saving works of God to fallen humanity. Interestingly, Judith A. Bauer appropriately refers to this divine promise as, "the first pledge of the Good News.,

Soteriologically, this divine promise of salvation refers to the continuing enmity that exists between the New Eve (i.e., the Holy Virgin Mary) and the devil (Rev 12:1); and it also implies the enmity between her offspring (i.e., Christ) and the angels of the devil. Remarkably, this ongoing enmity became quite evident during the crucifixion of the Savior on the Calvary. According to Ethiopian Tewahedo interpretation of the Psalmist's prophecy: "You crushed the heads of Leviathan" , Christ, the Son of the Blessed Virgin, struck the head of the devil on His mighty cross. Consequently, the devil had stricken the feet of the Savior with nails upon the cross (In 19:23, 34; 20:25).

In referring to this surpassing mystery of salvation, St. Paul aptly speaks: "But when the fullness of time had come, God sent his Son, born of a woman ... in order to redeem those under the law, so that we might receive adoption as children" (Gal 4:4-5). In the

light of this Pauline assertion, it could be clearly understood that the given divine promise of salvation has been realized through St. Mary. Interestingly, Ethiopian exegetes correlate the designation 'woman' that Christ particularly used to address to His beloved mother in the Gospel with her ideal of the 'promised woman' as prefigured in the First Testament. To clarify this, it suffices to mention what Christ the Savior said to His mother, the Holy Virgin Mary at the Wedding feast at Cana as well as when He saw her beneath the cross at Calvary. That is why St. John the evangelist and the beloved disciple of Christ, inspired by the Holy Spirit writes, "And Jesus said to her, 'Woman, what concern is that to you, and to me?'" (In 2:4); "Woman, here is your son" (In19:26).

Typically, it is quite fascinating to note the striking parallel that exists between the First Eve and St. Mary, the Second Eve. Unlike the disobedience of Eve, which brought about sin and death and curse unto humankind, the obedience of the Holy Virgin (i.e., the New Eve) brought about life and blessing to fallen humanity. In asserting this, one of the texts of the Praise of Mary reads:

The Virgin Mary, the God-bearer, hath become the object of the boast of us all, because through her was destroyed the curse of olden time, which rested upon our race, through the wickedness which the woman committed (when) she ate (of the tree). Through Eve was the door of the Garden shut fast, and because of Mary the Virgin it hath been opened to us again. It is allotted to us to eat of the Tree of Life, that is to say, the body of Christ and His precious Blood.,, As he reflected on St. Mary's prominent role in the economy of salvation, St. Irenaeus shared the same view and rightly referred to the Blessed Virgin Mary as "Eve's Advocate Hence, the disobedience of Adam and Eve and their subsequent expulsion from paradise anticipated their restoration through the wonderful mystery of the incarnation of the Son of God from the New Eve, the Holy Virgin Mary. Also, of significance in this regard is the Ethiopian Church' Tradition, which maintains that the Blessed Virgin was kept in God's mind even before the creation of the world. This in tom reveals the very fact that the incarnation of the Son of God is not only just a divine response to the fall Rather, it had been planned and designed eternally by God. Accordingly, the divine Logos made use of the flesh of St. Mary as His redemptive instrument (opyavov) the same way just as the devil had made use of the serpent's flesh

for his tricky deception (Gen 3:14; 1 Jn 3:8). Exceedingly, one of the Marian hymns illustrates this saying: "Thou was named 'Beloved Woman,' 0 blessed among women Our Redeemer Jesus Christ became incarnate of thee without change, and became the Mediator of the New Covenant and by the shedding of His Holy Blood, He purified the believers ... And because of this we all magnify thee, O our Lady, thou ever pure God bearer.

Thus, the Holy Virgin is prefigured symbolically and foreshadowed prophetically in the Old Testament, especially in relation with her supreme role in the economy of salvation. St. Gabriel's Annunciation to St. Mary and subsequently her faithful consent and humble obedience to God is looking forward to the Nativity, the advent of the Messiah, which in tom inaugurates the New Testament. To this end, the four Gospels in general, and that of St. Luke's in particular, give a detailed account of the Blessed Virgin Mary. Of particular interest is the Lukan account with its richness of language and the vivid imagery used in describing her personality and showing her own words and the divine favor bestowed upon her.

Soteriological, Ethiopian Mariology considers the exuberant scene of the Annunciation in which the archangel St. Gabriel appeared to St. Mary as the reversal of the tricky appearance of the devil, the fallen angel that brought about death and corruption to humankind. Thus, the mystery of the incarnation is the ultimate loving response of the ever-gracious God to fallen humanity.

As far as the fall of humanity is concerned, the consent of Eve to the deceptive words of the devil, the fallen angel is a parallel case (Gen 3:4-6). Consequently, this became a leading cause for the transgression and subsequent condemnation of humankind to death and corruption. In contrast to Eve's disobedience, however, St. Mary, the New Eve, has reversed the case through her willful and faithful consent to St. Gabriel's glorious words of annunciation. Accordingly, her obedience has made the Incarnation possible (Lk 1:28-38).

Remarkably, the annunciation of the Blessed Virgin Mary has become the culmination of the Old Testament prophecy. This is vividly asserted in the famous phrase of the Church's Marian hymn, "With the words of his tidings, the Holy Gabriel sealed the prophecy of the prophets. The Ethiopian Orthodox Church essentially considers the

Lukan prologue of the annunciation episode as the basic foundation of its Christological reflections and Marian devotion as well. Moreover, the Church has also regarded this significant event to be the cornerstone for its dynamic stereological implications mainly due to its strong relationship Within Christology. Hence, the annunciation is seen as a profoundly "world-changing=" phenomenon.

By virtue of her own willful consent and faithful obedience, freely given to the realization of the divine plan of salvation at the Annunciation, the Blessed Virgin Mary directly cooperated in the fulfillment of the saving acts of God through incarnation. Accordingly, Ethiopic Mariology articulates the stereological implication of the annunciation: "As through the words of deception of Satan, the Angel of Error, the curtain of darkness was spread over the whole world, so through the words of the tidings of Gabriel, the Angel of Truth, the light of life was spread in the whole world." In amplifying the soteriological role of St. Mary, St. Yard, the famous hymnologist of the Ethiopian Orthodox Church remarks, "We have become quite closer from the earth to the highest heaven because of you since the Son of God became incarnated from you.,,63Evidently, this in turn vividly shows her decisive role in the economy of salvation. Abba Giorgis, of Gasecha who is also known as the Ethiopian Cyril, colorfully states, "If you seek Eve, then you shall find her there in the heavenly wedding feast as she is rejoicing in her daughter (i.e., St. Mary- the New Eve). According to him, the Blessed Virgin Mary is the tree of life from whose fruit we all shall eat and live forever. So we all are saved through her and shall become alive eternally by the partaking of the Body and Blood of her beloved Son Jesus Christ. Above all, it is quite evident that we are sanctified with the precious blood of her Son throughout the ages. In turn we have become pure and holy through the living water and blood sprung from the pierced side of her beloved Son, Christ our Savior On 19:34).

The Role of St. Mary in the our Salvation In the study of Mary as the hope of humanity we have seen the relation of Mariology to Christology.

The relation consists in the fact that Mary gave us the Son of God who brought “fallen humanity” back to God the Father. All the biblical symbols that Mar Jacob utilized for this purpose designate the interconnection between Christology and Mariology. The main aspects of this chapter can be delineated as follows

1) The “restoration of humanity” takes place with the incarnation and Mary gives a leading role in it. From the homily On the Virgin, let us recapture Mar Jacob’s line of thought. Blessed is she, for by means of her, joy came to Adam’s race; through her the fallen arose who had been cast down from the house of the Father.

2) Mary, as the forerunner of the Church in her pilgrim way, is a model for the Church. Thus, Mary is the type of the Church.

3) We have also seen in this chapter the relevance of ecclesial, sacramental life. For example, in the symbol of the “Ship of treasures” we have seen that the desolate earth is enriched by the treasures, and in the light of Mar Jacob’s work we understand the treasures as faith, Baptism and Eucharist.

4) In bringing out the theme of salvation through the symbol of the “new pitcher of Elisha”, Mar Jacob has effectively pointed to the interconnectedness between Mariology and Christology. We will conclude this chapter with the beautiful words that Mar Jacob puts into the mouth of Mary as she bears her Son in her womb.

In order to have the right understanding of Mar Jacob’s conception on the participation of Mary in the redemption, it is necessary to have a fuller knowledge of his conception of the redemption. According to Mar Jacob divine mercy is the source of salvation. Christ came down to redeem fallen humanity. After Adam had been defeated, humankind took to idol worship and was subject to death. In order to redeem the world from idol worship and death, Christ “the fashioner of babes”, fashioned for Himself a body in the womb of Mary.

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Mar Jacob’s thoughts on the divine motherhood of Mary. Here the various Biblical symbols employed to describe this mystery are briefly analyzed. They are: “ark of the covenant”, “second heaven”, “shining castle”, “pure temple”, “celestial chariot”, “new well”, “tabernacle”, and the “cloud of Mount Sinai.”

The symbolic presentation of Mary as the “ark of the covenant” remains unique. In calling Mary the “ark of the covenant”, Mar Jacob convinced the readers that Mary’s character was excellent without any spot, and just like pure stainless gold, she was the worthiest person in the whole of humanity in whom the Son of God dwelt.

Soteriologically, the life of St. Mary is most closely linked with the redemptive works of God. This is precisely because whenever we remember what God has done in the economy - Christ's

miraculous virgin birth, His flight into Egypt, His public ministry. And especially His crucifixion and sacrificial death, it is impossible to separate the Mother of God from salvation history.

This is mainly because she is the one who gave birth to the Savior, who is persecuted with Him during their flight in to Egypt and is associated with His public ministry and who was never departed from Him even at the last moment beneath the Holy Cross. All of these steps clearly show the vigorous involvement of St. Mary in the economy of salvation.

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According to Ethiopian Tewahedo interpretation of the Psalmist's prophecy: "You crushed the heads of Leviathan" Christ, the Son of the Blessed Virgin, struck the head of the devil on His mighty cross. Consequently, the devil had stricken the feet of the Savior with nails upon the cross (In 19:23, 34; 20:25). • In referring to this surpassing mystery of salvation, St. Paul aptly speaks: "But when the fullness of time had come, God sent his Son, born of a woman ... in order to redeem those under the law, so that we might receive adoption as children" (Gal 4:4-5). In the light of this Pauline assertion, it could be clearly understood that the given divine promise of salvation has been realized through St. Mary.

Interestingly, Ethiopian exegetes correlate the designation 'woman' that Christ particularly used to address to His beloved mother in the Gospel with her ideal of the 'promised woman' as prefigured in the First Testament.

To clarify this, it suffices to mention what Christ the Savior said to His mother, the Holy Virgin Mary at the Wedding feast at Cana as well as when He saw her beneath the cross at Calvary. That is why St. John the evangelist and the beloved disciple of Christ, inspired by the Holy Spirit writes, "And Jesus said to her, 'Woman, what concern is that to you, and to me?'" (In 2:4); "Woman, here is your son" (In19:26).

Through Eve was the door of the Garden shut fast, and because of Mary the Virgin it hath been opened to us again. It is allotted to us to eat of the Tree of Life, that is to say, the body of Christ and His precious Blood. As he reflected on St. Mary's prominent role in the economy of salvation.

St. Irenaeus shared the same view and rightly referred to the Blessed Virgin Mary as "Eve's Advocate Hence, the disobedience of Adam and Eve and their subsequent expulsion from

paradise anticipated their restoration through the wonderful mystery of the incarnation of the Son of God from the New Eve, the Holy Virgin Mary.

Thus, the Holy Virgin is prefigured symbolically and foreshadowed prophetically in the Old Testament, especially in relation with her supreme role in the economy of salvation. St. Gabriel's Annunciation to St. Mary and subsequently her faithful consent and humble obedience to God is looking forward to the Nativity, the advent of the Messiah, which in tom inaugurates the New Testament. St. Yard, the famous hymnologist of the Ethiopian Orthodox Church remarks, "We have become quite closer from the earth to the highest heaven because of you since the Son of God became incarnated from you.

ኤራቅሊስ ፬ ፰ • ፲፰፤አ ከርሥ ዘተጽሕፈ ውስቴታ መጽሐፈ ግእዛን እምግብርናት ለኵሉ ሰብእ። ለሰው ሁሉ ከመገዛት የነፃነት መጽሐፍ ለተጻፈባት ማለት ሰውን ሁሉ ከግብርናተ ዲያብሎስ የለየ ክርስቶስ ለተፀነሰባት መንፈስ ቅዱስ ላደረባት ማኅፀን አንክሮ ይገባል። አ ከርሥ ዘተፀውረ ውስቴታ ንዋየ ሐቅል ዘይትቃወሞ ለሞት በእንቲአነ። ስለኛ ሞትን የሚቃ ወም የበዳ ፀብት የተሰቀለባት ዘተገብረ ቢል የተለንጸባት ማለት ሞትን ድል የነሣባት ክርስቶስ ላደረባት ለተገኘባት ማኅፀን አንክሮ ይገባል።

“በእንተ ሔዋን ተዓጽወ ኖኅተ ገነት፥ ወበእንተ ማርያም ድንግል፥ ተርኅወ ለነ ዳግመ፥ ከፈለነ ንብላዕ እምዕፀ ሕይወት። ዘውእቱ ሥጋሁ ለክርስቶስ፥ ወደሙ ክቡር። [The gate of Paradise was shut because of Eve; and it is re-opened for us on account of the Virgin Mary. He made us eat from the Tree of Life, which is the precious body and blood of Christ].

“በከመ ይቤ ኢሳይያስ፥ ‘ትወጽእ በትር እምሥርወ ዕሤይ፥ ወየዓርግ ጽጌ እምጕንዱ።’ ውእቱኬ ወልድ ውእቱ። ወአልቦ ማኅለቅት ለመንግሥቱ። [As Isaiah said, ‘A shoot shall come out from the stump of Jesse, and a branch shall grow out of his roots’ (Isa. 11:1); it is the Son to Whose reign there is no end].

“ቀዳሚሁ ቃል፥ ነሥአ መሬተ እምድር፥ ወለሐኰ ለአዳም፥ በዘዚአሁ አርአያ ወአምሳል። ቀዳሚሁ ቃል እምአብ ውእቱ፥ እምድኅረ ለሐኰ ለአዳም፥ ርእየ በውስቴቱ ብእሲተ፥ ከመ ባሕርይ ፅዕዱተ ውብርኅተ፥ ለውሉደ ሰብእ ትኵን መድኃኒተ።

[The eternal Word took dust from the earth and fashioned Adam in His own image and likeness. The eternal Word is from the Father. After He fashioned Adam, He saw a woman in him that was like a pure and radiant pearl that is to be a medicine for humankind.

“ኢየሐፅፅ ወልድ እምህላዌሁ ለአብ፥ እንዘ ሀሎ ምድረ፥ ኀቤነ ነገረነ ዛናከ። ወማርያምሰ ተንከተመ እግዙአብሔር፥ ኮነት ለነ። ዚቲ ይእቲ ትምክህትነ። ስምዓ ግዕዛንነ። ተወልደ መድኃኒነ፥ ፍሥሐነ ወክብርነ።

[The Son was not diminished from the existence of the Father. While on earth, He told us about Your news. And Mary has become the ladder of God for us. She is our pride, the emblem of our deliverance. Our Savior, Who is our joy and glory was born. Lastly, the prophet Daniel saw an image of the divine maternity of the Holy Virgin in the form of a high mountain from which is found a stone which crushed the great image into dust whose remnants are carried away by the wind and saved the people: "But the stone that struck the statue became a great mountain and filled the whole earth" (Dan 2:34-35). Remarkably, the stone came forth from the mountain without being pushed with human hand. Referring to this, the Anaphora of St. Mary aptly says,

"Thou was the first giving birth without intercourse of which Daniel (also spoke)." The coming down of the stone from the mountain without the aid of a human hand symbolizes the virgin birth of the Savior from the Blessed Virgin Mary.

Thus, this prophetic vision is meant to assert the divine maternity of the Holy Virgin Mother of God. In highlighting the stereological significance of this remarkable vision, the Marian hymn of Ethiopian Church articulates: "This is the stone which Daniel the prophet saw, which was hewn from a high mountain without hands, that is to say the Word going forth from the Father. He came and became incarnate of the Virgin without seed of man, and delivered us.

As Ethiopian exegetes allegorized the stereological implication of this image, the stone symbolizes the divine word of God; its coming from a high mountain shows the humble descent of the Son of God from the heavenly bosom of His Father; and the coming of the stone down from the mountain without the aid of human hands elucidates the incarnation of the Word from a Virgin mother without a human father. Besides, it is quite interesting to note how this Marian hymn particularly emphasizes the salvation of humanity as the ultimate purpose of the incarnation. Most importantly, in this remarkable vision Daniel reveals that the stone, cut out from a high mountain without human hand, struck the great image and became like a mountain. Soteriologically, this seems to have foreshadowed the divinization of the flesh by virtue of the incarnation,

After cursing the Evil Dragon for misguiding Adam and Eve, God promised to send a woman whose offspring would crush the head of the serpent (Gen. 3:15). According to Orthodox theologians, this "woman" is the Virgin Mary and her "offspring" is Christ. For this reason, Christ used the Biblical term "woman" to refer to His beloved Mother (Jn.2:4; 19:26), indicating that the Virgin Mary is the New Eve and the fulfillment of the prophecy. Rather than dishonoring St. Mary, the term "woman" exalts her status in the Church and in the history of salvation. The Virgin Mary is, indeed, the victorious woman who destroyed the head of the serpent and who, through her son, emancipated humankind from satanic slavery. As the woman predicted to give birth to the Son of God, St. Mary was prophetically expressed in many symbolical representations.

She is associated with the heavenly ladder Jacob dreamed of during his flight to Haran (Gen. 28:10) and is believed to be a bridge between the Old and the New Testaments, because she was predetermined to reunite man with God through her Son, Jesus Christ. On account of her nativity, the fountain of sin was dried; man reconciled with God, and was granted access to paradise and eternal salvation. St. Ephrem the Syrian (306-373 A.D) was reported by Vassall-

Phillips to be one of the Church fathers who identified St. Mary with Eve and considered the former to be the gate of salivation (Ez. 44:2; Gen.28:17) and the predestined means of restoration for the life of the corrupted human generation. As St. Ephrem explains, "Those two innocent, those two simple ones, Mary and Eve, had been indeed quite equal the one to the other: but, afterwards, one became the cause of our death, the other of our life."[4]

According to Richard Brennan, St. Epiphanius of Salamis (315-403 AD) asserts the position of the Virgin Mary in the Orthodox context and pronounces, "The Blessed Virgin surpasses in glory the first of the heavenly powers. Only God is above her. All that is not God she sees beneath her feet."[5] He also details the role she plays in human salvation and the grounds for her glorification through thee, O Blessed Virgin, has celestial peace been given to the world. Through thee have men been made like to the angels; through thee have they received the honorable titles of servants, friends, and children of God. Through has death been overthrown and hell conquered. Thou hast destroyed the Idols, and brought back to men the knowledge of heavenly things. Through thee have we known the Son of God, Whom thou, O holy virgin, hast borne?[6]

The patristic writer St. Irenaeus (202 A.D) further explains the relation between Eve and Mary:

As Eve was deceived by the word of the Angel of darkness, and fell from her obedience to God, so through Mary was proclaimed the word of an Angel, that if she obeyed she would carry God in her body; and as the devil had induced the former to abandon God, the latter would be moved to follow and obey him, and thus become a mediator. Again, as the whole human family was made subject to death by a virgin, so was it delivered from the same death by a virgin, inasmuch as the obedience of the latter cancelled and made good the disobedience of the former. Finally, as the sin of the first man was obliterated by the sufferings of the Son of God, so did the simplicity of the dove win a victory over the cunning of the serpent, in order that we might be loosed from the chains that bound us.[7]

Abba Heryacos encapsulates the dynamic role the Holy Virgin Mary plays in the salvation of the

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4 O. R, Vassall-Phillips, *The Mother of Christ or The Blessed Virgin Mary in Catholic Tradition, Theology and Devotion* (London: Bums, Oates &Washboume, 1922), p. 39.

5 Richard Brennan, The means of Grace: A complete exposition of seven sacrametns (new York: Benziger Brothers, 1894), pp.517-518

6 Ibid.

7 Ibid.,517.

world: "You were the hope of Adam when he was driven out from paradise, the meekness of Abel who was killed through unrighteousness, the kindness of Seth, the works of Enoch, the ark of Noah through which he was saved from evil's destruction."[8]

The Orthodox Church of Ethiopia exalts the Holy Virgin Mary because of her contribution to human salvation, placing her above all saints but below God. The faithful regard the Theotokos as an interceder and invoke her name during Divine Liturgy and private prayers, saying, "O Holy one Pray for us." We can see some verses of the Ethiopic Anaphora and haimanot Abew about Her purity and Theotokos

Abba Heryacos: "When God the Father saw your purity He sent you his radiant angel, named Gabriel, and he told you: The Holy Spirit shall come upon you, and the power of the Highest shall overshadow you/[9]

The Mariological manuscript of Archbishop Heraclius (died c. 580) translated into Geez read: "ኢያእመረ የሴፍ እስመ ዘተፈጥረት እምነ ጽቡር ጽሩይ ትከውን መቅደሱ ለእግዚአብሔር " St. Josepha had no clue if the virgin created out of pure dust would be a dwelling house to God"[10]

Theodous bishop of Ancyra (died c.446) writes of the virgin: ወኢረኩለት በምንትኒ እምዘፈጠራ"[11]

St. John Chrysostom: "ከመዝ እግዚእነ ሶበ ረከበ ሥጋሃ ቅዱስ ለዛቲ ድንግል ወነፍላ ቅድስተ ፈጠረ ሎቱ መቅደሰ ዘቦቱ ነፍስ"(For God found the body and the soul)of the virgin spotless, he created him a sanctuary (His body) consisting of a soul.[12]

2.1 Covenant of perpetual Virginity

A woman of extraordinary gifts chosen by the Holy Spirit to be the throne of God, St. Mary vowed to remain ever virgin. Her own words to the Angel of the Lord demonstrate that she had no intention of ever marrying because she knew what the plan of God was about her. When St.

[8] Marcos Daoud & Bilata Marsie Hazen, trans., The liturgy of the Ethiopian Church (Addis Ababa: The Ethiopian Orthodox Church Kingston,1991),p.76.
[9] Marcos daoud & marise Hazen, Bilata, trans, The liturgy of the Ethiopian church (Jamaica : the Ethiopian orthodox Church Kingston, 1991)p,77.
[10] Ethiopian orthodox Tewahedo Church, Haimanote Abew (Addis Ababa: Tensaea Zegubaea Printing press, 1951),p.157
[11] Ibid., 174.
[12] Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Churuch, Haimanote Abew (Addis Ababa: Tensaea Zegubaea Printing Press, 1951),p.237

Gabriel said to her, "behold, thou shalt conceive," her answer was, "How can this be, since I am a virgin?" (Lk. 1:34 St. Mary was described in Old Testament prophecy as an exceptional woman who would give birth miraculously to an everlasting God. This Divine plan was evidently revealed to the Prophets. Isaiah points out, "Therefore the lord himself shall give you a sign; behold, a virgin shall conceive in the womb, and SHALL bring forth a son" (Is. 7:14).

The Virgin Birth was necessary for the incarnation of God. If he had not been conceived by the Holy Spirit, Jesus would never have been accepted as the son of the Living God. Christ, the Son of God, could never have originated in the reproductive system of the corrupted generation. Solomon's description of "a Unrein enclosed," "a fountain sealed," and "a well of living waters" sheds light On St. Mary's virginity. The Living Water that issued from the fountain was Jesus Christ, who Himself said, "Let him that is thirst come...take the water of life freely" (Rev. 22:17). Being the secured fountain of the Living Water and the bridegroom of the Holy Spirit, the mother of God could not be espoused to an earthly husband. As Solomon said, she is sealed forever. God also uncovered the mystery of St. Mary's chastity to the prophet Ezekiel, who writes, "The Lord said to me: This gate shall remain shut; it shall not be opened, and no one shall enter by it; for the Lord, the God of Israel, has entered by it; therefore it shall remain shut" (Ezek. 44:2).

A further purpose of the Virgin Birth was to impress upon humankind that the expected Messiah would be spotless, free of ancestral sin, and capable of redeeming those who live in condemnation. It is for this reason that Jesus Christ is called the Second Adam. The first man was brought into existence out of untouched earth. Similarly, St. Mary gave birth to the Second Adam without a human father, for ancestral sin was assumed to be transmitted only by means of a man/woman relationship. St. Mary's Virgin Birth, on the other hand, was accomplished by the intervention of the Holy Spirit (Mt. 1:20).

Almost all Post-Nicene Church Fathers have articulated the perpetual chastity of the Holy Virgin Mary in light of the Holy Scriptures. Some of these affirmations are stated below, as quoted by Vassall-Phillips. St. Epiphanies harshly blasts opponents of St. Mary's Virginity in the following terms: "Some men [the new heretics] have ventured to outrage with insult that Holy and Blessed

Virgin, saying that after the wondrous and virgin mystery of the Lord's Incarnation she suffered the loss of virginity--a thing which surpasses all other wickedness and impiety."[13]

Jerome writes, "The garden which was enclosed, the fountain that wan sealed up, is a figure of the Mother of the Lord, Mother and virgin. Hence in the Savior's new sepulcher which was hewn in most hard rock, no one was laid either before or after. Yet, this perpetual Virgin is the mother of many virgins. And according to St. Proclus, the disciple of St. John Chrysostom: "Unless His Mother had remained a virgin, her offspring would have been but man, and the mystery of the Birth would have been lost. But if after her childbearing she remained a virgin, how shall not He be God and a Mystery which is unutterable?[14]

2.2 Titles and symbols of the Virgin Mary

Patristic fathers and scholars who pay homage to the Holy Virgin Mary as the mother of God employ various symbolic expressions and titles offered to St. Mary in the Bible associated with her Divine maternity and human redemption. Among the manifold titles Orthodox theologians use in their invocations are the Theotokos and the Mother of Mercy. The Greek word Theotokos (bearer of God) was attributed St. Mary at the third Ecumenical Council to proclaim the Divinity of Jesus Christ and her station as the mother of God. The Council was summoned by St. Cyril of Alexandria at Ephesus in 431 A.D. to investigate the heresy of Nestorius, the Patriarch of Constantinople (428-431), who refused to accept the Godhead of Christ and preferred to call the Virgin Mary Anthropotokos (Bearer of a man).

Patriarch Nestorius was strongly exhorted by the assembly of the saintly fathers not to breach the universally accepted apostolic doctrine. Nevertheless, instead of being responsive to the pleadings of the fathers, he insisted on referring to the Virgin Mary as Gpamlokoc Anthropotokos (Bearer of a man)or Tololkoc Christotokos, "the mother of Christ" because he believed that Christ is a mere man. Finally, the council accepted St. Cyril's reasoning, reaffirmed the deity of Christ, and approved the title) 0 eotokc Theotokos for the Holy Virgin Mary. The council also unanimously passed a canonical resolution which anathematized Nestorius and his

[13] O. R, Vassall-Phillips, *The Mother of Christ or The Blessed Virgin Mary in Catholic Tradition, Theology and Devotion* (London: Bums, Oates &Washboume, 1922), p. 58.

[14] O.R, vassal- Phillips, The mother of Christ or the blessed virgin Mary in Catholic Tradition, theology and devotion (London: Burns, Oates & washbourne,1992),p.57

erroneous teachings, stating: "If any one does not profess that Emmanuel is truly God, and that consequently the Holy Virgin is the Mother of God--inasmuch as she gave birth in the flesh to the Word of God made flesh, according to what is written: The Word was made flesh'-lei him be anathema."[15]

Most Post-Nicene Fathers of the Christian Church echoed the council's position. For example, St. Gregory Nazianzen wrote, "Let him who will not accept Mary as the mother of God be excluded from God."[16] The Virgin Mary has been given additional designations such as the Blessed Mother, the Star of the Sea, the Queen of Heaven, and the Cause of Our Joy.

2.3 The paradise and untilled ground

The Mother of God has been demonstrated in patristic writings with the following expressions corresponding in meaning to Untilled Ground: The Paradise of Eden, the Virginal Soil, and the Earth that produced Adam. These symbolic titles reflect her moral excellence of saintliness, Motherhood, and Perpetual Virginity. The Virgin can be mystically thought of as a golden purse wherein we treasure the medicine of our life (the Eucharist,) and as a guide to the lost generation who moved away from the darkness of transgression, developing self-awareness by means of the Gospel, and returned to its ancestral home through Christ.

A passage taken by Vassall-Phillips from St. John Chrysostom provides a detail account of this topic. Chrysostom writes, "The word Eden signifies virgin land. Now, such was the region in which God planted Paradise. For it is written that God planted a Paradise in Eden towards the East, that thou mayest understand that Paradise was not a work of human hands; since the earth was virgin, and had known no ploughshare, nor was it cut up by furrows; but without tillage - at the Divine command alone it put forth its vegetation and trees. For this reason He called it Eden, which means virgin soil. This virgin earth is a type of the Virgin. For as that land, without having received any seed, blossomed forth for us Paradise; so too Mary, without having conceived of man, blossomed forth for us Christ. When then a Jew says to thee: How did a Virgin bring forth? Say to him: How did the virgin earth put forth those marvelous trees?"[17]

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[15] *Joseph Pohle,* Mariology, A Dogmatic Treaties on the Blessed Virgin Mary, Mother of God *(ST. Louis: Herder 17 South Broadway, Mo., 1914), p. 5.*

[16] *Ibid.. 9.*

[17] *O. R, Vassall-Phillips.* The Mother of Christ or The Blessed Virgin Mary in Catholic Tradition, Theology and Devotion *(London: Bums, Oates & Washboume, 1922), p. 377.*

2.4 The ark of Noah

The ark of Noah allegorically represents the apostolic church in general and the Holy Virgin Mary in particular. The Ark was built with the Divine guidance of the Holy Spirit to carry Noah and his family and thereby save the human race him total annihilation (Gen. 6-10; 1 Peter 3:20). The Holy Virgin Mary was despondingly protected from Adamic sin by God's divine providence and was illuminated by the Holy Spirit to be aware of herself as a predestined woman and to prepare herself for the mission of God. Indeed, Mary is the Ark of Noah, because she played a dynamic role in human redemption, bringing forth fuel, the Savior of the world. For this reason, the Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church recognizes the Virgin Mary as an Adamic seed miraculously saved from ancestral corruption. In the words of the Prophet: "And if the Lord of babaoth had not left us a seed, we should have been as Sodom, and we should have been made like Gomorrha" (Is 1: 9).

2.5 The ark of the Covenant

The Ark of the Covenant presented to Moses was the Tablet of Law consisting of Clod's commandments. Holding the Ark of the Covenant on the way to the Land of Hope, Israel crossed the River Jordan and destroyed the wall of Jericho. In the Ark of the Covenant, God addressed His message to Moses and the people of Israel. To Moses he said, "I will speak to thee above the propitiatory between the two cherubs, who are upon the ark of testimony" (Ex 25:22).

Typologically, the Holy Virgin Mary is an Ark of the New Testament, a Tablet of the Law carrying the Lawgiver and the Word of God for our redemption. For this reason St. Ephrem says, "O Mary, sacred ark, whereby we are saved from the deluge of sin."[18]. The children of Israel were able to gain power and defeat their adversaries during their sojourn in the wilderness in part because they carried the Ark of the Covenant (Zion) received from their religious fathers. We, the Orthodox, place our hopes in St. Mary to help us defeat our adversary, Satan, cross the river of sin and enter the kingdom of God.

2.6 The ladder of Jacob

On the way to Haran where his uncle Laban was residing, one of the three Hebrew Patriarchs, Jacob, was tired from his long journey and lay down at a place to sleep for the night. In his sleep,

[18] *O. R, Vassall-Phillips,* The Mother of Christ or The Blessed Virgin Mary in Catholic Tradition, Theology and Devotion *(London: Bums, Oates & Washboume, 1922), p. 383.*

he had a vision of a shining ladder. It was "set up on the earth, and the top of it reached to heaven: and behold tin* angels of God ascending and descending on it. And, behold, the LORD stood above it" (Gen 28: 13). This was the predestined mystery of incarnation revealed to the man of God. In this mystical revelation, the ladder symbolizes Theotokos, the cause of our reconciliation. Essentially, because St. Mary was united to Divinity within her womb, man was reconciled to God and earth to heaven.

Jacob continues to describe his dream of the ladder: "And the Lord stood upon it, and said, I am the God of thy father Abraham, and the God of Isaac...How fearful is this place! This is none other than the house of God and this is the gate of heaven" (Gen. 28:13-17). Orthodox Tewahedo Church scholars teach that God reveals Himself to His beloved children in one way or another. In this context, Jacob was able to experience God and His celestial Angels through his dream of the ladder. The dream prognosticated that the invisible God would assume human flesh from the Virgin Mary and become visible in the fullness of time. When Jacob awoke from his sleep, he became aware that the place where he had been resting during the night was the "house of God" and he called it "Bethel." This symbolized that the actual New Testament Church would be established after the incarnation of the Logos from the Virgin Mary. Thus, both the Church and St. Mary represent the dwelling place of God. The Son of God receives worship and glorification both in the Church and in the womb of His beloved mother.

The ascending and descending of Angels demonstrates their ministry to Saint Mary. Archangel Gabriel appeared to the Virgin Mary and announced to her the birth of our Savior, Jesus Christ (Lk.l:26). Saint Joseph received an Angelic message encouraging him not to be afraid to take Saint Mary, the bride of the Holy Spirit (Mt.l:18). In a dream, an angel told St. Joseph to flee to the wilderness and continued providing help to the Holy Family during their flight to Egypt (Mt. 2:13).

A ladder can serve as a bridge to unite people separated by deep valleys. St. Mary is a bridge that unites the old and the new generations through Christ. Abba Heryacos says, "How marvelous

and wonderful is this thing! O bridge over which the ancient fathers crossed from death unto life! O ladder from earth to heaven, through you the first creation was renewed."[19]

2.7 The burning bush

The day, while Moses was watching over his father-in-law's flock on Mount, he saw a burning bush and the Angel of the Lord appeared to him in the of fire. The bush burned but was never consumed, and Moses drew nigh to higher loose thy sandals from off thy feet for the place where on thou stadest is holy ground. Then he said, “I am the God of your father, the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac and the God of Jacob.” At this, Moses hid his face, because he was afraid to look at God.” (Ex. 3:1-5).

The burning bush in the Orthodox Traditional exegesis symbolizes St. Mary, who conceived the Word of God in her womb without being ravaged by the consuming fire" of Divinity (Heb. 12:29) and gave birth to Jesus Christ without losing her Virginity. St. Ephrem the Syrian writes, "In the fire Moses saw thy beauty in shadow, O daughter of David, in whose bosom dwelt that Flame, and thou wert not consumed, O Mother of God who art fall of grace."[20] This mystical symbolization should be soundly elaborated using allegorical exegesis. The sanctity of the scene reflects the sanctity and righteousness of the Virgin, and the taking off of sandals represents avoiding ambiguity about the Godhead of Jesus Christ who assumed human flesh from the Virgin Mary (The Unconsumed Bush).

2.8 The rod of Aaron

Early on in Biblical history, God sought to end the grumbling of Israelites by nominating a religious leader. He commanded Moses to collect a rod from each tribe and put them in the tabernacle of witness. When Moses took all the rods out in the morning, it was found that the rod of Aaron, from the tribe of Levi, had miraculously blossomed and produced almonds (Num. 17:1-8).

According to the Church fathers, Aaron's lifeless rod, which blossomed without planting or watering, symbolizes the Holy Virgin Mary who gave birth to the Lord without receiving human seed. Christ is the Fruit of life that was given to Christians in the form of Holy Eucharist. There

[19] Marcos Daoud & Bilata Marsie Hazen, trans., *The Liturgy of the Ethiopian Church* (Addis Ababa: The Ethiopian Orthodox Church Kingston, 1991), p. 76.
[20] *O. R, Vassall-Phillips,* The Mother of Christ or The Blessed Virgin Mary in Catholic Tradition, Theology

were other young women serving at the temple at the time St. Mary was presented to God. Yet the Virgin Mary's immaculate life drew the attention of God. Abba Heryacos considers that God's choice of the Virgin Mary was based on her spotlessness: "When God the Father saw your purity He sent you his radiant angel, name shall also the coming of the Son of man be" Mt. 24:27)."And his feet shall stand in that day on the Mount of Olives, which is before Jerusalem on the east" Zach .14:4).

On account of her saintliness and divine maternity, the Virgin Mary the "Innocent Dove" who brought good news to Noah concerning the receding Of the Great Flood (Gen. 8:11). She is referred to as a dove by virtue of her • meekness and for having given birth to the Son of God. She is the "Golden | Censer" which contains incense and fire, symbolizing humanity and divinity respectively and attesting to her patience and endurance in giving birth to Son of God called a "consuming fire" (Heb. 12:29). Abba Heriacos was astonished at the marvelousness of this endurance and says, "O Virgin, when there abode in your womb the fire of the Godhead, Whose face is fire, whose clothes are fire, whose covering is fire, how did it not bum you?"[21]

Church fathers also refer to Mary as the "Second Heaven," the abode of God (Zion), or the "City of God" (Ps 87:3-5). She is the "Golden Lamp" which contains the light of the world (Jesus Christ) (Jn. 8:12), and the "Pot of the Manna" which carried the bread of life (the Eucharist) to the hungry world (John 6:32).

[21] *Marcos Daoud & Bilata Marsie Hazen, trans.,* The Liturgy of the Ethiopian Church *(Jamaica: The Ethiopian Orthodox Church Kingston, 1991), p. 79.*

CHAPTER THREE

3. Veneration of the holy Virgin Mary

The Holy Virgin Mary has a central role in human salvation. Biblical and patristic writings substantiate Mary's Divine Maternity. The Theotokos was mystically envisioned in the minds of many Old and New Testament writers illuminated by the Spirit of God. The veneration of the Virgin Mary is associated to her divine maternity. One of the Major Prophets, Isaiah, foresaw that a Virgin would give birth to a Son, Emmanuel. According to Isaiah, her miraculous birth established that she was the Mother of God (Is.7:14) and her Son's name, Emmanuel, signifies "God is with us." Emmanuel, who came to us through a Virgin Birth, should never be assumed to be a mere man. As depicted by the same prophet, He is the "Mighty God," "Everlasting Father," and "Prince of Peace" (Is. 9:6).

At the fulfillment of the prophecy, celestial beings were able to recognize St. Mary as the Mother of God. For example, an Angel of the Lord referred to as St. Gabriel appeared to the Virgin Mary and said, "You will name him Jesus. He will be great, and will be called the Son of the Most High....He will reign over the house of Jacob forever, and of his kingdom there will be no end" (Lk 1:31). Among Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers, Joseph Pohle cites St. Athanasius and St. Gregory Nazianzen. St. Athanasius wrote, "We confess that the Son of God became man by the assumption of flesh from the Virgin mother of God."[22] And St. Gregory Nazianzen asserts, "Let him who will not accept Mary as the mother of God be excluded from God."[23]

As mentioned earlier, any homage, veneration or glorification offered to the Theotokos should focus on her unique intercessional grace and, specifically, what she has contributed to the world as the Mother of God. The Psalmist describes St. Mary as an immaculate Queen who shall be praised everlastingly by all subsiding generations, standing at the right hand of God: "Hearken, O daughter, and consider, and incline thine ear; forget also thine own people, and thy father's house; so shall the king greatly desire thy beauty: for he *is* thy Lord; and worship thou him....I will make thy name to be remembered in all generations: therefore shall the people praise thee forever and ever" (Ps. 45:10- 17). The wise man, King Solomon, seeing the same woman in a

[22] *Joseph Pohle,* Mariology, A Dogmatic Treatise on the Blessed Virgin Mary, Mother of God *(ST. Louis: Herder 17 South Broadway, Mo., 1914), p. 9.*

[23] *Ibid.*

divine vision, described her spotlessness and her wonderful nature, predicting that all queens and concubines shall praise and call her the "blessed one." He expresses her taintlessness with the phrase "my undefiled is but one." He also admires the grace of her beauty and the power of her spirituality, attesting that she is brighter than the sun and the moon (Son of Song 6:10).

As an Ark of the Covenant and the Divine Throne of God, St. Mary merits supreme glorification, indeed, second only to the Divine worship we offer to God. The Prophet Isaiah transcribes God's words to the Mother of God: Kings shall be thy nursing fathers and their queens thy nursing mothers: they shall bow down to thee with fheir face toward the earth, and lick up the dust of thy feet; and thou shalt know that I am the Lord" (Is 49:23).

When God sent St. Gabriel to announce the Holy Virgin Mary, he proclaimed: "Rejoice, highly favored one, the Lord is with you; blessed are you among women!"(Lk.l:28).When she was visited by Holy Virgin Mary, St. Elizabeth wondered, "But why is this granted to me, that the mother of my Lord should come to me? For indeed, as soon as the voice of your greeting sounded in my ears, the babe leaped in my womb for joy" (Lk. l:43). The adoration of St. Gabriel and St. Elizabeth offered to the Virgin Mary were the direct result of her Divine Maternity. According to Joseph Pohle, St. Athanasius confirms that * Virgin Mary is full of grace because, as he says, "Being filled with the holy Spirit, she overflowed with all graces, and was overshadowed by the power of the Most High."[24]

The Orthodox Church of Ethiopia refers to St. Mary as the "Tabernacle of Moses," the "Second Heaven," the "City of God or Zion," and the "Pot of Manna."[25] We find Mariological treatises in the writings of Joseph Pohle validating St. Mary's Divine Motherhood in three fundamental senses: "(1) that it confers upon her a rank vastly superior to that of any other creature; (2) that it constitutes her the very center of the hierarchy of rational creatures, and (3) that it makes her an intermediary between God and the universe."[26]

[24] *Joseph Pohle, Mariology,* A Dogmatic Treaties on the Blessed Virgin Mary, Mother of God *(ST. Louis: Herder 17 South Broadway, Mo., 1914), p. 26.*

[25] *H.H. Pope Shenouda III,* Comparative Theology *(London: Coptic Orthodox Publishers Association, 1988), p, 112.*

[26] *Joseph Pohle, Mariology,* A Dogmatic Treaties on the Blessed Virgin Mary, Mother of God *(ST. Louis: Herder 17 South Broadway, Mo., 1914), p. 16.*

Most essentially, St. Mary views herself as the Mother of God and is certain that she will be venerated by subsequent generations: "For behold, henceforth all generations will call me blessed"(Lk.l:48). When we venerate the Theotokos as the Mother of God, we express our love and due respect to her, and invoke her name not only for eternal salvation but also for aid in the miscellaneous needs of our temporal life. As Pope Shenouda III says, "Whoever venerates the Virgin is in effect venerating Christ Himself."[27]

3.1 Patristic writings of St. Mary

The virginity of St. Mary is not a matter of her own private life, but rather a 'Biblical reality', which belongs with our faith in Jesus Christ. For when the Word of God was Incarnated, He was not particular about the kind of place where he would be cradled, or the clothes He would wear, or the food He would eat; but He was definitely very particular about the Virgin who was to be His mother[28]

3.1.1 Hippolytus (c. 215) states: "Do you believe in Christ Jesus, the Son of God, who was born of the Holy Spirit and the Virgin Mary?"[29] This argument was used also by the early Christian apologists, such as St. Justin and Athenagoras, in their defense on behalf of Christianity.

3.1.2 St. Ignatius of Antioch (m. 110 A.D.), preached this Virginal Birth as one of the great Christological (dealing with Christ) mysteries, which were loudly proclaimed to the world in his time:

"The virginity of Mary, her childbirth, and also the death of the Lord". These were hidden from the prince of the world. Three mysteries loudly proclaimed but wrought in the stillness of God.[30]

3.1.3 St. Irenaeus*;* Those who proclaimed Him Emmanuel, born of the Virgin, (Isa.7: 14) proclaimed also the union of the Word of God to His handiwork, "because the Word will become flesh, and the Son of God will become the Son of man, the Pure one opening purely that pure womb, which generate men into God…" *St. Irenaeus*[31]

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[27] *H.H. Pope Shenouda III,* Comparative Theology (London: Coptic Orthodox Publishers Association*, 1988), p, 111.*

[28] J. B. Carol: Mariology, 1955, Vol. 1, p. 51

[29] The Apostolic Tradition of St. Hippolytus 21:15

[30] St. lgnatius: Epist. Ad Ephes. 19:1

[31] Adv. Hear. 4:33:11. PG 7:1080

* Christ opened the silent, spotless and fruitful womb of the Holy Church, for the birth of God's people. *Ambrose*[32]

3.1.4 Ephram the Syrian * Your divine birth, O Lord, gave birth to all creatures. Mankind gave birth to You in the body;

and You gave birth to mankind in spirit. Praise to You, who became a Child, to make all things new! *St. Ephram the Syrian*[33]

3.1.5 St. Cyril of Alexandria * As Christ appropriated a body taken from a woman and was engendered by her according to the flesh, He recapitulated in Himself the generation of man. *St. Cyril of Alexandria*[34]

3.1.6 St. Gregory the Wonder-Worker*;* From on high came the divine Word, and in your (St.Mary's) holy womb reformed Adam (new creation in Christ). *St. Gregory the Wonder-Worker*[35]

3.1.7 St. John Chrysostom; The Son of God has become the Son of David; do not doubt that you, a son of Adam, may become the son of God. If God had stooped to such an extreme depth, He has not done so in vain, but to raise us to a sublime height. He was born of flesh that you might be born again according to the spirit! He was born of a woman that you might become a child of God. *St. John Chrysostom*[36]

3.1.8 Theodosius of Ancyra; The Son of God made Himself man, that we might welcome Him as a member of our own family, and despite our sins we might be born again to hope. * We have fled far away from our Teacher, leaving behind the grace He offered us; and what does this Master in His mercy? He pursues the fugitive to bring him back. He approaches him not clothed in majesty but with a lowly aspect adopted in Mary's womb, and in that guise becomes his familiar and his friend, making Himself a servant with us that we may became masters with Him. *Theodosius of Ancyra*[37]

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[32] Com. On Luke 2:57 PG 15:1573

[33] Hymn 3 on Nativity

[34] PG 76 : 23

[35] PG 76:15-18

[36] PG 10:1151

[37] In Sanctam Delporem, hom 4

3.1.9 St. Gregory of Nyssa; (Virginity) is a necessary door to a holier life. It is the channel which draws down the Deity to share man's state, it creates wings for man's desire to rise to heavenly things, and it is a bond of union between the Divine and the human, by its mediation bringing into harmony these existence's so widely divided.

* It has been proven as well that this union of the soul with the incorruptible Deity can be accomplished in no other way than by attaining the greatest possible purity - a state which, being like God, will enable one to grasp that state of virginity which reflects the purity of God like a mirror in which one's own image becomes moulded with beauty at the touch and sight of the Archetype of all beauty….

St. Gregory of Nyssa[38]

Just as (the Lord) made His entrance when the doors were closed, in the same way did He come forth from the Virgin's womb, because this virgin really and truly gave birth without pain. Her virginity remained safe and sound. *St. Ephram the* Syrian[39]

[38] De Virginitate 2, 11

[39] Explanatis evangelli concordantis, ch 2:6, 8.

CHAPTER FOUR

4. The Theology of holy Cross

The mysterious meaning of the word Cross in the theological context connotes the way how we achieved everlasting joy due to the great love of God, and the passion of Christ that we received for our salivation. which cannot be seen in flesh but can be contemplated, and those Christians who received persecution as bearer of the Cross having faith of the only Son of God Jesus Christ. Literally, the Cross is a means for the proclamation of everlasting peace, the throne of love, a sign of peace, and our pride to resist the evil one. Based on these, indigenous Ethiopian scholars taught and wrote about the glory of the Holy Cross. St. Yared and the golden age figure Abba Giorgis of Gasicha are among the Ethiopian scholars who witnessed the glory of the Holy Cross. Hence, it is better to present their thought in the following subtitles for Christians when we celebrate the finding of the True Cross.

4.1 The Holy Cross is the power and wisdom of God that made devil to be ashamed and flee

"If Satan knew his defeat by the Cross of the Son, he wouldn't urge Jews to crucify and kill Christ the Nazareth, who is the redeemer." Satan was defeated by the Cross he implanted with mischief and felt ashamed by his own false advice to the Jews.

"He made a pit and dug it and is fallen in to the ditch which he made" (Ps7; 15) St Yared relate his hymn with this psalm of David and amplified the value of the cross for us to be purified from the evil mind and a means to have the sprinkling precious blood of Christ on the Cross which pushed Satan out from believers' heart. (ICor1; 18) Zemare (a hymn of St.yared.p136)

In relation to this, when he explained about what was hidden to us before the ages "How amazing is his deed about the Cross-which ashamed Satan, destroyed the consequence of sin on Soul and flesh, avoided corruption of the human body. The power and wisdom of the Cross is amazing and wonderful. "(I Cor 2:7 Haymanote Abew Ze Kidus Athnatewos, The book of Ziq and Mezmur: p.21) The Cross is the accomplishment of love by which Satan tied up, the love of God for us is revealed. Condemning Satan, we believed in Christ and saved by his Cross. We have seen the love of God for us by means of the Cross.

"By the power of the Cross Satan was arrested. Today the Cross is glorified, the world is saved, God is praised, and man achieved freedom" (Degua-ze Meskel).

The Cross is an altar on which the Lamb of God, who takes away the sin of the world, is crucified (Jn. 1:29), a means of joy for those who were saddened, as sung by St. Yared.

"He was crucified on the Cross by His own will like a meek lamb he followed the slaughterers to be slaughtered. By this the world became bleached, the sad for 5500 years rejoiced, first person Adam who became poor by losing his grace is saved from his poverty." By this he meant that the Cross is the way, God revealed His love for us on it, a means that changed the word in our Sinner ears "But we are all as an unclean thing, and all our righteousness is as filthy rages…" (Isa.64:6/, and enabled us to hear the voice of mercy, accomplishment of love and unchangeable testament. St. Yared praised the Holy Cross in the above hymns that beautified Ethiopia and prospers the human bones. /Rev 13:18, Degua-Zemesekal/ Really the altar of our salivation, the Cross is a shield of body and soul, a real rest for broken heart, and a state of conciliation for disturbed minds, /Zemare: p.82/

The Cross is a charter of reconciliation in which we heard the merciful voice of God and a means of our restoration from migration. "While He was on the Cross, the Son of God, Christ cried to His Father and said "forgive your hand's work, do not destroy your own creature, do not leave the creature of your right hand as wandering or disappearing."

"Adam disobeyed the law and ate the fruit of the tree. But, O Father look at the Cross on which they crucified me as a sinner" Saying this on behalf of Christ, St. Yared tells us that the Cross destroyed our transgression, and brought complete peace to our conscious. The Cross is a means to attain the mercy of God when we sinned against God. /Heb. 9:29/ and a means of restoration from our miserable life. /Gen. 3:22, Zemare Ze-Fasika: p.86, Luke 23:34/

The Holy Cross is an altar on which Christ, the arch priest of the Father, presented Himself as a chosen sacrifice to restore our original state, and to reconcile us with His Father, the Holy Spirit and with Himself. It is a permanent charter or reconciliation according to St. Yared's hymn in the fifth part of Zemare called Mestir, which is specifically dedicated to the mystery of the Eucharist. (p.163). Of course, being a man of sorrows, surely, He has borne our grief and carried our sorrows, and crucified in order to free us from the bondage of sin. /Gen. 3:6, Isa 53:3, Saint Yared/ As it is written in the book called "Metshafe Kidan", "our reliance is on the cross to praise it." Because of the first Adam everybody was dead, but, by the Cross of the second Adam all became alive. "We are ransomed by the blood of the Cross and sin will not rule on our body

again." /Rom. 6:8, Icor.15:2/ We are also heard that He opened the paradise by His Cross. (Saint Yared). After St. Yared, who always remembers the cross in his entire life saying, "how sweet are the words of the cross to my throat" Abba Giorgis of Gasicha, the great scholar of the 14th century, explains the theology of the Cross in a very deep mystery as the following.

The Cross is a vessel which contains the bread of life, and in it the Christ's mystery of salvation is fulfilled." The Lamb of God was slaughtered on the Cross by the hands of the crucifiers and a dining table of blessing is prepared for the believers."

"Truly, pure sacrifice is Jesus of Nazareth, the son of holy calf." By saying this elaborated the role of the Holy Cross in our salvation in his detail and deep taught. /Eph.1:7, Metshafe Mestir p.140, Monday's Arganon/ The one who eats from this meal of blessing will not be hungry again and will have an everlasting life. For this purpose, Christ Himself was the lamb for the sacrifice, the priest who presented the sacrifice and the Cross was an altar. With these circumstances our salvation is accomplished and He proclaimed His love by mercy./Jn.6:51/

The one who has no any blame, our paschal lamb, Christ was slaughtered on the Cross, Because, of this, the meal of life is prepared for believers./1Cor.5:7/ And again, Abba Giorgis, who is called the pillar of religion, when he explained about the perfect salvation acquired by the Cross, said, "the Cross, which is the redeemer of all humanity, deserves salutation" By saying this, praise with contemplation, he translated Christ's mystery of salvation by interrelating with the word of the Apostle. /2Cor.5:19.

4.2 The Cross is the Foundation of Faith and the pillar of Religion

"Your Cross is the foundation of faith and a pillar of religion for those who believe and relay on you. Having said this he witnessed that the Cross is a pillar which cannot be shaken by demons, a means to mortify those who stood on us, and a sign which is given to skip from the face of the arrow." Ps 59:4, Wedasie Meskel (Prasise of the Cross) by Abba Giorgis/ In addition, when he explained the glory of the Cross, he said: "Christ is the light which daily shines on His saints and His Cross is the stand of the light in the church. And the blood of Christ for the redemption of the world is shaded upon it."

In general, though it is difficult to summarize the theology of the cross in this module, as mentioned in the introduction, the Cross transmits a message of reconciliation and agreement, a means for the salvation of Adam, who was given for destruction, a tree of life which restored Adam to his original state. A tree for the remission of sin, a source of life, foundation of our salvation, above all things the prophecy of prophets, Apostle's sermon, paradise of the saint's joy, rest for sinners, and retreat for Satan. Having the inspiration of the Holy Spirit both these indigenous scholars taught the theology of the Cross as mentioned above /2pet, 1:21, Zemare P.155/. The church, who follows the footsteps of the apostles, on the bases of the patristic taught, witnesses saying "we received grace and we have gained life by the power of the Cross of Jesus Christ. Because of this witness, members of the Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church, who washed their clothe by the blood of the lamb, have special place in their heart for the love of the Cross. / Rev.17;14/ They say, "Our hope in the heaven and on Earth is this Cross." With this song of victory, they have celebrated the anniversary of the True Cross for centuries and it will be continued without having lost its special place of honor until the end of the world. Praise be to the Cross of Christ, the tree of medicine, which is our power and strength! Source: Taken from "Bulletin" prepared by Ethiopian Orthodox Tewahedo Church Publication Committee for 2008/2016 anniversary of the True Cross.

John of Damascus

The tree of life which was planted by God in Paradise pre-figured this precious Cross. For since death was by a tree, it was fitting that life and resurrection should be bestowed by a tree. Jacob, when He worshipped the top of Joseph's staff, was the first to image the Cross, and when he blessed his sons with crossed hands he made most clearly the sign of the cross. Likewise, also did Moses' rod, when it smote the sea in the figure of the cross and saved Israel, while its overwhelmed Pharaoh in the depths; likewise, also the hands stretched out crosswise and routing Amalek; and the bitter water made sweet by a tree, and the rock rent and pouring forth streams of water, and the rod that meant for Aaron the dignity of the high priesthood: and the serpent lifted in triumph on a tree as though it were dead, the tree bringing salvation to those who in faith saw their enemy dead, just as Christ was nailed to the tree in the flesh of sin which yet knew no sin. The mighty Moses cried, you will see your life hanging on the tree before your eyes, and Isaiah

likewise, I have spread out my hands all the day unto a faithless and rebellious people. But may we who worship this obtain a part in Christ the crucified Amen.[40]

St. John Chrysostom

"The Cross is for our sakes, being the work of unspeakable Love towards man, the sign of His great concern for us. "For to this end Christ both died, and rose, and revived..." And so, let us at least convince you that He is thoughtful for our salvation. He then that has shown so mush anxiety about our becoming His, as to take the form of a servant, and to die, will He despise us after we have become so? This cannot be so, assuredly it cannot! Nor would He choose to waste so much pains, "For to this end (he says) he also died," as if anyone was to say: Such an one will not have the heart to despise his servant. For he minded his own purse. For indeed we are not so much in love with money, as is He with our salvation. Wherefore it was not money, but His own Blood that He gave as bail for us. And for this cause He would not have the heart to give them up, for whom He had laid down so great a price."

The cross is the most powerful Christian symbol in the whole world of Christians. The Orthodox Church gives high esteem to this symbol. The cross speaks much more than its form. It is an invitation to follow Jesus Christ. It is a vocation to Christian discipleship. The cross strengthens the disciple to follow and imitate Jesus Christ. Without the cross, no one can follow Jesus Christ. 'And whoever does not carry their cross and follow me cannot be my disciple' (Luke 14.27). The cross is the Christian hope that helps the faithful to lead their pilgrim life on the earth. The love and obedience of Jesus Christ is seen in its utmost form on the cross. "God is love; and the Holy Cross is nothing other than God's love. Love has the character of the cross. The power, fire and nature of love consist in the fact that love has the character of the cross; and there is no love that does not have the character of the cross."[41]

The cross of Christ is the key that opens the gates of heaven. The Christians venerate and adore the cross because it helps them to fight against the evil forces of the world, it strengthens them to overcome the doubts of faith, and it supports them during the failures and renews them by giving hope for a better future.

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[40] St. John of Damascus De fide Orthodoxa: an exact exposition of the Orthodox Faith Page 210

[41] Sergiĭ Bulgakov, *Churchly Joy: Orthodox Devotions for the Church Year* (Grand Rapids, Mich.: William B. Eerdmans Pub. Co., 2008), 2.

4.3 Sign of the Cross in Prayers

The sign of the cross was in use long before the cross itself came into general use. The use of the sign of the cross is very ancient and is frequently referred to by the early Christian writers. As far back as the third century Tertullian made this comment on the custom: "At every coming in and going out, in lying down or sitting, we mark our foreheads with a little sign of the cross."[42]In the synoptic Gospels, we read that Jesus Christ asking his followers to take up the cross and follow him. 'To take up the cross' is a phrase that is rich in meaning which presents Jesus Christ suffering and death as a model for discipleship. "From the second half of the second century the early Christian texts mention the sign of the cross, signing oneself, someone else or some object for sanctification."[43] The early Christians used the sign of the cross to exorcise the demons and to ward off the evil spirits. They also branded their cattle with a cross mark, as they believed this symbol kept the evil spirits away. "The sign of the cross has been in use since Apostolic times. It is a confession of faith in Christ and an expression of gratitude and reverence."[44] The followers of Christ made the mark of the cross to show that they belonged to Jesus Christ. By this symbolic mark, they professed their faith in the crucified Christ. Thus, the sign of the cross became much identified with the faith in Christ. "It is a way of confessing Jesus Christ crucified with one's

"St. Cyprian states that it is the authoritative use of the sign of the cross which works the effect in all the sacraments."[45] The act of making a sign of the cross is a public and visible yes to the Lord and Christ, who made God's love visible on the cross. The sign of the cross is a confession of faith to the crucified and resurrected Christ who reigns by the humility of love and suffering which is stronger than all power in the world and wiser than all intelligence in the world. "In making the sign of the cross, the symbol was used to encapsulate the entire economy of salvation and the power of God that accomplishes it."[46]

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[42] Benson, *The Cross: Its History and Symbolism*, 113.

[43] Van Tongeren, *Exaltation of the Cross: Toward the Origins of the Feast of the Cross and the Meaning of the Cross in Early Medieval Liturgy*,1

[44] Benson, *The Cross: Its History and Symbolism*, 116.

[45] Beresford-Cooke, *The Sign of the Cross in the Western Liturgies*, 6.

[46] Viladesau, *The Beauty of the Cross: The Passion of Christ in Theology and the Arts, from the Catacombs to the Eve of the Renaissance*, 42.

4.4 The Meaning of the Sign of the Cross

The sign of the cross is the confession of Christian faith in Christ who suffered and died on the cross, but through his resurrection, he transformed the sign of shame into a sign of hope. By making the sign of the cross the faithful place themselves under the protection of the cross. The cross serves as a shield which guards the believers against the battle of the evil powers. The cross is not only a sign of passion but it also represents the resurrection. The cross acts as a saving staff and a bridge through which the faithful cross the abyss of death and reach the safe harbor of God.

The sign of the cross is also a confession of faith in the triune God and it sums all essence of Christianity. By his death on the cross he offered us the truest possible sacrifice and abolished the guilt and through his resurrection he called the humanity to a new life. "In the light of the incarnation, the cross is the event and the sign not of suffering or defeat, but of God's triumphant glory."[47] During baptism, there was the ritual of anointing the forehead with oil in the form of the cross. This was a branding which said that the person after his baptism completely belongs to Christ, sharing Jesus paschal mystery and death. During this period, the cross symbolized God's salvific power of resurrection and salvation. "For baptism and sign of the cross, which is a kind of summing up and re-acceptance of baptism, are above all a divine event, whenever we make a sign of the cross we accept our baptism anew."[48]

CHAPTER FIVE

5. Theological significance of the Veneration of the holy Cross

The Holy Cross derives its theological significance from its relationship with Jesus Christ' salvific death on the cross. This unique relationship is briefly explained in the first part. The Good Friday liturgies of both Traditions are imbued with a lot of symbolism and meaning. In the second part, the symbolic significance of the Holy Cross is elucidated.

[47] Viladesau, *The Beauty of the Cross: The Passion of Christ in Theology and the Arts, from the Catacombs to the Eve of the Renaissance*, 37.

[48] Ratzinger, *The Spirit of the Liturgy*, 178.

A deep reflection and study on Jesus Christ' death reveal that the cross not only stands as the instrument for Christ's death but also serves as the instrument for Christ's resurrection. Resurrection is a mystery that is beyond time and space.

The theology of the Holy Cross is very much highlighted in the official documents of the Orthodox Church.

5.1 The Soteriological Significance of the Holy Cross

The Merriam-Webster online dictionary defines soteriology as 'the theology dealing with salvation' as especially effected by Jesus Christ.[49] The soteriological significance of the Holy Cross comes from its relation with the sacrifice and passion of Jesus Christ. "The cross planted in shame and ignominy has grown through the ages in the hearts of men to become the symbol in mystic beauty and power of the spirit of Jesus Christ.[50]" The death of Christ is an indispensable salvific event for the redemption and salvation of humankind. Christ's death is not a mere death but it is an expiatory sacrificial event.

Sacrifices have an important place in the Jewish liturgy and Old Testament. Sacrifice is the offering of the most precious thing to God as a gift. From the time of Abel and Cain, the earth was covered by the smoke of burnt offering and the blood of sacrifices. In the sacrifice the one who offers offer oneself and the offerings to God out of his or her love towards God. Sin caused rupture from God and life. Under the bondage of sin humanity became mortal and powerless. "All the sacrifices, however, were powerless to destroy sin and restore the fullness of unity with God that man had forfeited[51]."

Only God can save humanity, therefore, God gave His only begotten Son for the salvation of the world in ultimate, perfect and all-embracing sacrifice where the salvation of humanity is accomplished. Through the one and unrepeatable sacrifice of Christ, humanity is restored and renewed. "In his sacrifice is forgiveness of all sins, all the fullness of salvation and sanctification,

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[49] Merriam-Webster, https://www.merriam-webster.com/dictionary/soteriology [accessed April 25, 2017].

[50] Benson, *The Cross: Its History and Symbolism*, 190.

[51] Alexander Schmemann, *The Eucharist: Sacrament of the Kingdom*, trans., Paul Kachur (New York: St.Vladimir's Seminary Press, 2000), 103.

the fulfillment and therefore the completion of all religions[52]." As a sacrificial lamb, Jesus Christ offered Himself on the cross and shed His blood as the ransom for the salvation of humanity.

Christ's gift of His life as a ransom suggests a contract made in order to obtain freedom for slaves. The main idea is that of liberation attained through the compensation of a redemption price. The cross is the instrument that makes Jesus Christ' death a sacrificial event. As a sacrificial lamb Christ offered himself on the cross but through His resurrection, he became a triumphant king and achieved victory over sin and Satan. It is the world which is anointed with the blood which flowed from the body of the lamb. The cross is also anointed by the blood of the lamb. "The blood which has flowed in the sacrifice of the lamb, that is to say, Christ's death on the cross, has anointed the cross.[53]"

The cross is a primary theme of the redemption and salvation of humankind in the early liturgy and writings of the Fathers of the Church. The Salvation of the humankind, the redemption of humanity from sin, restoration of humanity to the primordial state of grace, are the important salvific events that find its origin on the cross. These soteriological events directly make a link between cross and Christ and thereby it moves on to God.

5.2 The Cross: The Instrument of Salvation for Humanity

"The cross is the instrument of salvation, but this instrumental significance of the cross obtains an extra dimension because the cross is also a sign, a mystery that refers to salvation.[54]" In many liturgical prayers, the cross is addressed as the instrument that brought salvation to the world. The daily Eucharistic sacrifice reminds the faithful that there is no salvation except in the Cross of Lord Jesus Christ. In the Gospel of John, we can see a connection between Jesus Christ' crucifixion on the cross and His exaltation. It is not the exaltation of the cross, for John, but the exaltation of Jesus Christ is the central theme. 'And when I am lifted up from the earth I will draw everyone to myself" (John 12:32). According to the fourth Gospel, through His death on the cross, Jesus Christ effects salvation and eternal life to the world.

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[52] Schmemann, *The Eucharist: Sacrament of the Kingdom*, 105.

[53] Van Tongeren, *Exaltation of the Cross: Toward the Origins of the Feast of the Cross and the Meaning of the Cross in Early Medieval Liturgy*, 242.

[54] Van Tongeren, *Exaltation of the Cross: Toward the Origins of the Feast of the Cross and the Meaning of the Cross in Early Medieval Liturgy*, 220.

"In the Synoptics, the death and glorification of Jesus Christ are two chronologically separate events while in John they form a unity" The exaltation of the cross is the exaltation of Christ himself. The cross itself mediates salvation because it has salutary significance due to Jesus Christ' death on the cross. In the narrative of John, the cross itself means triumph.[55] Hence the cross is a symbol that mediates and represents salvation. The cross consecrated by Christ effects a continuing, salutary bliss, and thus takes on an eschatological significance. On the cross, Jesus Christ is the glorified Lord and crucified king who with His passion and death paid the ransom for the liberation of the world and so He exercises His universal kingship from the cross. Jesus Christ' kingship is linked with the cross; Jesus Christ is the eternal king reigning from the cross.[56]

The ultimate aim of Jesus Christ on the cross is the salvation of the whole world. As it is the will of the Father, Jesus Christ, Son of God offered himself as a sacrificial lamb on the cross in order to accomplish salvation. Jesus Christ' silence on the cross is to be seen as His complete surrender and total obedience to the Father. This total obedience is compared as the silence of a sacrificial lamb before the slaughters. This allegory is seen in Orthodox Tradition. The Orthodox Tewahido mass text says: "He never opened His mouth, like a lamb that is led to the slaughter-house, like a sheep that is dumb before its shearers never opening its mouth."

The salvation that Jesus Christ brought on the cross is for the whole world and humanity. In the plan of salvation, God has never excluded anyone. The faithful receive the salvation that is brought out by Jesus Christ on the cross in and through the Church. This does not mean that the Church only gives the fruits of salvation to her children alone. The Church wants all humanity to accomplish this salvation that is brought out by Jesus Christ.

Jesus Christ on the cross, by His bloodshed, has planted the seeds of salvation for the whole human race. The ceremony of the celebration of the Holy Cross, towards four directions, in the Orthodox Liturgy vehemently highlights the theme of the salvation of the whole universe. By having faith in Jesus Christ, the human race is called to achieve this salvation.

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[55] Cf. Alan E Lewis, *Between Cross and Resurrection: A Theology of Holy Saturday (Grand Rapids*: Eerdmans, 2001), 37.

[56] Cf. Van Tongeren, *Exaltation of the Cross: Toward the Origins of the Feast of the Cross and the Meaning of the Cross in Early Medieval Liturgy*, 241.

5.3 Redemption of Humanity on the Holy Cross

One of the main results of Jesus Christ' death on the cross is the redemption of the humanity. Jesus Christ is called as the divine Redeemer who won the merits of redemption on the cross. Through His death on the cross, Jesus Christ redeemed the sinful humanity from the slavery of sin. Therefore, for the followers of Christ, the cross becomes the sacred instrument of redemption.

The cross becomes the visible sign of redemption that is brought by Jesus Christ' passion and death. "As sign and meaning, the cross and redemption is related to each other: the signified manifests itself in the sign and inversely, the sign reveals the signified." The cross is a sign of redemption on which the precious and salvific blood of Jesus Christ' flowed for the redemption of all humankind. As the instrument of redemption, the cross is at the same time its embodiment; it is the earthly sign of redemption. By His death on the cross, Jesus Christ redeemed the lost paradise and made it accessible for the faithful. The theme of redemption is also seen in the prayers of the Exaltation of the cross.

The salvific significance of the cross lies in paradise again becoming attainable, made accessible again for the believer through faith in this cross."[57]

Adam's disobedience contrasts with the obedience of Christ on the cross. It is through Adam's disobedience that humankind comes under the dominion of the devil. By His death on the cross, Christ descended into hell and opened the gates of Hades and freed Adam who was defeated and killed by the power of sin. By freeing Adam from hell Christ became the second or new Adam. By his obedience to his Father Christ recapitulated the first Adam and thereby Christ became the second Adam. Christ the Son of God became man i.e Adam by his incarnation. The divine became human in order to make the humans divine, to make them sons and daughters of God. "Christ was exiled from heaven to bring us back to heaven. His filial obedience reversed the primordial disobedience. He shared God's wrath with us so that we should share God's grace with him."[58]

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[57] Van Tongeren, *Exaltation of the Cross: Toward the Origins of the Feast of the Cross and the Meaning of the Cross in Early Medieval Liturgy*, 109.

[58] Tony Lane, "Bernard of Clairvaux: Theology of the Cross," in *The Atonement Debate: Papers from the London Symposium on the Theology of Atonement, ed. Derek Tidball*, David Hilborn, and Justin Thacker (Michigan:

Jesus Christ' death on the cross as the redemption of Adam, as a representative of humanity, is an important theme in the Orthodox liturgy. It is repeated many times, throughout many prayers, in the whole liturgy. There is an interesting comparison on this theme. According to Genesis, Adam was created on the sixth day of the week which is Friday. Jesus Christ also is crucified on Friday. Thus Friday, the sixth day, becomes very significant in the theme of restoration in a Good Friday liturgical song.

"On this Friday God redeemed Adam back to Paradise
On this Friday like a leaf sky covered Lord's nakedness.
On this Friday Adam has lost his grace by eating fruit
This Friday Lord died on the Cross and brightened all Adam's race." [59]

5.4 Restoration of Creation on the Holy Cross

The salvific events on the cross took place to restore the creation to its glory before the fall. The word restoration in this context means bringing back the status of glory. The creation enjoyed a status of joy, peace and order in the paradise. Adam's sin broke this order and as a result, all the creation came under the bondage of sin and evil. God wanted to reestablish the divine order in the creation. The Oriental theology considers the mystery of incarnation as the restoration of humanity. "Incarnation is an act of God's philanthropy, to restore us to communion with himself. God became man in order to restore God's image in man that was impaired by the fall." Love is the force and spirit that works in all divine principles. In order to establish a world-order of love, God, who is love, became human to teach humanity the path of love. 'For God so loved the world that he gave his one and only Son, that whoever believes in him shall not perish but have eternal life' (John3: 16).

By incarnation, Jesus Christ gave the message of love through his words and deeds. 'A new command I give you: Love one another. As I have loved you, so you must love one another' (John 13: 34). The utmost example of love is seen on the cross. The sacrificial death of Jesus Christ on the cross is the result of God's love towards humanity. "The love manifested by Jesus

Zondervan, 2008), 252.

[59] Ramban, *Holy Liturgy of the Passion Week*, 76.

Christ on the cross is, that which exceeds all comprehension." Therefore, one can say that the cross is the best symbol to characterize divine love.

The theme of restoration is seen in the prayers. "Praise be to the acceptable oblation who offered Himself on the wood of the Cross and cleansed our guilt by Him being offered up in sacrifice for our sake; who died and restored us to life by His death."[60] In this prayer, Jesus Christ' death is made as the cause of life for the humanity. The cross and Jesus Christ' death become the principle for eternal life. In the Orthodox liturgy, it is shown that Jesus Christ' death restores joy to the whole world. "We adore your cross, o Lord, we praise and glorify your holy resurrection, for behold, because of the wood of a tree joy has come to the whole world." The prayer in the liturgy says that Jesus Christ by His death on the cross restored the humanity to life from the clutches of death and sin. "Almighty ever-living God who have restored us to life by the blessed death and resurrection of your Christ, preserve in us the work of your mercy, that, by partaking of this mystery, we may have a life unceasingly devoted to you. Through Christ our Lord."

Restoration of Adam was the eternal plan of the Almighty God. Adam was created in the image of God. The salvific history is the message of God's love for the restoration of creation. In the power of the Holy Spirit Christ accomplished this restoration which was the will of the Father. Therefore, the human restoration of life from sin and death is the result of God's love. What Adam failed to attain in the paradise has been made attainable by Jesus Christ on the cross. The lost paradise was thus regained and restored on the cross. "Hence the cross of Christ is the turning point, the reentry into Paradise, the moment of reconciliation and the encounter with God in response to the divine promise of immortality through the vision of God in the eschatological Paradise."[61]

It is on the cross that Jesus Christ accomplished restoration. The wood of the tree in Eden is in contrast with the wood of the cross. Through the wood of the tree in Eden Adam brought sin, oppression, and death to humankind; through the wood of the cross, Christ brought joy, liberation and resurrection to humankind. The cross is the key that unlocks the Garden of Eden which was locked by the disobedience of Adam. Jesus Christ' sacrificial death on the cross

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[60] Ramban, *Holy Liturgy of the Passion Week*, 112.

[61] Thomas Kollamparampil, "The Cross of Christ and Christian Life," in *The Folly of the Cross*, ed. Paulachan P. Kochappilly(Bangalore: Dharmaram Publications, 2000), 38.

opened the gates of paradise. Faith in the cross allows the faithful to accomplish salvation and redemption. "The underlying concept is the idea that humankind, fallen in and through Adam, is restored to its original state through Jesus Christ."[62]

5.5 Salvation Accomplished on the Holy Cross

Salvation is an important theme in our liturgical Tradition, the faithful venerate of the Holy Cross for its soteriological effects. The defeat of evil is very much linked with the defeat of death. Christ conquered death by his death and resurrection. Satan who held the power of death is defeated on the cross. On the cross, Christ destroyed both the power of devil and death. Before the death of Christ, the dead faced only the darkness of the grave. Because of sin, the humans were separated from God and they were under the subjugation of sin and death. "Truly 'all is accomplished' on the cross; nothing greater can be thought of or done; it was there that every human and divine resource was consumed; all evil is conquered at its roots, salvation is obtained and every glory is given to the Trinity."

5.6 Revelation of God's Love on the Holy Cross

God's love towards humankind is best revealed on the cross. Incarnation comes to its culmination on the cross. The Incarnated Word of God, lived, suffered and died on the cross out of His love for the suffering humanity. "On the Cross, he took upon himself the sins of the world."

Jesus Christ' passion and death on the cross should be understood as the primordial plan of God. Jesus Christ gives Himself over to the Father in the obedience of love in order to bring the world back to the Father. A deeper reflection on the mystery of Christ's death on the cross reveals the role of the Trinity. One can say that the Holy Cross on the Mount of Calvary is the revelation of the Trinitarian love. The faithful who believe in Jesus Christ is called to model their life after this ultimate love that is pictured on the cross.

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[62] Van Tongeren, *Exaltation of the Cross: Toward the Origins of the Feast of the Cross and the Meaning of the Cross in Early Medieval Liturgy*, 88.

The cross becomes the revelation of the Trinitarian God. When the Christians venerate the cross, they actually invoke a prayer to the divine power of the holy and life-giving cross, the God the Father and the Holy Spirit itself. "Together with the sacrifice on the cross of the Son of God, this is the sacrifice of the entire Holy Trinity, consubstantial and indivisible. Only the Son became incarnate and suffered on the cross, but in Him was revealed the sacrificial love of the entire Holy Trinity; of the Father who sent Him and of the Holy Spirit who reposed upon him." Christ on the cross reveals the love of God. Christ's death on the cross is the revelation of divine love. It is not only the sacrifice of the Son of God but it also reveals the love of Father and Holy Spirit.

CHAPTER SIX

6. The Symbolic Significance of the Holy Cross

The symbols in the liturgy have the basic function of expressing and narrating the message of salvation history in a meaningful way. Most of these symbols have the Biblical foundation. "These symbols will help the faithful to grasp the mysterious, transcendental nature of the Almighty and the realities of heavens. It provides a chance for the faithful to encounter God through Jesus Christ and the power of the Holy Spirit."[63] It is from Jesus Christ' passion, death and resurrection that the cross derives its symbolic value and it becomes a central Christian symbol.

The Gospel of St. John gives a theological meaning for the cross. For John Jesus Christ' lifting up on the cross is his glorification. He identifies Jesus Christ' death on the cross to his royal exaltation. The Gospel of John reinterprets the finality of the cross and gives it a new 'resurrection' meaning.[64] It is on the cross that the Son of man, terrestrial Jesus is identified with glorified Lord. Thus, John makes a vital link of identification between the suffering Christ and glorious Lord on the cross. Christ's death, torment, and torture on the cross were all willed by the Father. God the Almighty Father, so loved the world that he gave up his only Son to be crucified for the liberation of humankind from the bondage of sin. It is on the cross that Jesus Christ ousted the devil so that humankind can participate in resurrection. Jesus Christ' stretching out of

[63]Thykoottathil, *Christological Mysteries: A Contextual Study on the Liturgy of Saint James in the Syro-Malankara Church*, 46.

[64] Cf. Lewis, *Between Cross and Resurrection: A Theology of Holy Saturday*, 34.

the arms on the cross was a symbolic representation of the gathering of all peoples. "When I am lifted up, I shall draw all people to myself" (John 12; 32). The lifting up of Christ on the cross prefigures' ascent to heaven and his drawing of all people to himself.

For the Syriac Fathers, the Old Testament is a solid background and a great inspiration for the New Testament. In order to deal with their New Testament subject, they go deep into the Old Testament to find out the type and ideas that reflect their theme. For the Syriac Fathers, the New Testament is the fulfillment of the Old Testament as they believe that the Word of God is one and the same in all the scriptures. Many of the Syriac Fathers say that the Old Testament is inseparable from the New Testament. The divine mystery that is revealed through the incarnation, which is described in the New Testament, for the Syriac Fathers, is revealed through types and symbols in the Old Testament. The Syriac Fathers find a special interest in sketching a typological parallelism between the two Testaments.

"The Antiochene tradition of interpretation is widely preserved, marked with their own style. They interpret the Old Testament events literally, which serves as types for the New Testament in which these events find their meaning spiritually. Then they enter into the sacred time sacramentally to be fulfilled in the Eschaton."[65]

Therefore, the types and symbols are the easy instruments that reveal the aspects of hidden reality, for the Syriac Fathers. The cross is one of such types that reveal the mystery of God. By making a connection between the tree of paradise and the cross on the Mount of Calvary, the Syriac Fathers bring out the mystery of the economy of salvation into a comprehending vision.

6.1 The Holy Cross Symbolizes Victory

Christ underwent passion and death in order to acquit the humanity from the punishment that they deserved for their sins. Christ suffered a violent death on behalf of the humanity. He dies our death so that He can unite us to himself in his resurrection.[66] Through his resurrection, Jesus Christ achieved victory over death and sin. This victorious resurrection of Christ gives hope and salvation for the humanity. Sacrificial death on the cross paved the way for resurrection and salvation. It means that through His sacrificial death on the cross Jesus Christ could achieve his

[65] Karim, *Symbols of the Cross in the Writings of the Early Syriac Fathers*, 67.

[66] Cf. Andrew D. Swafford, "A Biblical Look at Divinization," in *Divinization: Becoming Icons of Christ through Liturgy*, ed. Andrew Hofer(Chicago: Hillenbrand Books, 2015), 32.

resurrection. Here the cross stands as the life-giving cross, which effects the salutary gift of salvation. Therefore, the cross itself is salutary and considered as a *vexillum*,[67] a banner of victory, its triumphal character is emphasized.

The triumphal character of the cross is also mentioned in many early works, such as, cross as a weapon of justice etc. "The cross is a weapon which God has placed in the hands of humankind in order to achieve victory, and at the same time is the banner which marks the triumph obtained."[68] By describing the cross as a *vexillum*, its triumphal character is emphasized. The cross is qualified as a weapon that effects salvation because it is on the cross that Jesus Christ becomes the messianic victor. The cross thus brought not only peace and salvation but protection and shelter from the powers of evil.

6.2 The Holy Cross Symbolizes the Bronze Serpent

"A typological connection is drawn between the cross on which Jesus Christ was lifted up and the bronze serpent that Moses lifted up on a pole in the desert. As this bronze serpent on the pole prevented the death of anyone who looked upon it, and healed them of poisonous snakebites, so the Son of man elevated on the cross will not allow the faithful to meet with, disaster, but he gives them eternal life."

Syriac Fathers Mar Jacob, Ephrem and Aphrahat write on this topic. According to the Syriac Fathers, the bronze serpent set by Moses is a type of cross. In his Homily 80:27 Jacob writes as follows. "He (Moses) drew His (Christ) body by making the bronze serpent, and by it he was healing all who were bitten by the snakes. The serpent had no venom, neither was sin found in our Lord's body who became like us."[69] This comparison of the cross with the bronze serpent that was erected by Moses in the desert gives a connection between the Old and the New Testament.

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[67] A military standard or flag carried by ancient Roman troops.

[68] Van Tongeren, *Exaltation of the Cross: Toward the Origins of the Feast of the Cross and the Meaning of the Cross in Early Medieval Liturgy*, 114.

[69] Karim, *Symbols of the Cross in the Writings of the Early Syriac Fathers*, 73.

6.3 The Holy Cross Symbolizes the Tree of Paradise

"In patristic and medieval typological exegesis and in liturgical texts, the tree in Paradise and Adam are frequently prefiguration's which are the typos or the figure for the cross and Christ, respectively."[70] In the earlier writings of the Church Fathers, we see a lot of analogy between the wood of the tree of paradise and the wood of the cross, also between Adam and Christ. By eating the fruit of the forbidden tree (Gen. 2:17) Adam closed off the salvation for the humankind, which can again be opened up by faith in the Wood, that is to say, faith in the cross that is central for the day on which this secret is prayed. The Salvation which was closed off by the wood (the tree) in paradise is opened by Jesus Christ on the wood (cross).

Salvation is made accessible through the cross or in other words the cross opened the salvation which was closed off once through the unthinking and premature eating from the wood (the tree). Through the wood of the cross, Jesus Christ made salvation accessible. For the Syriac Fathers, the tree of life serves as a type of both Christ and the cross. For the Syriac Fathers Christ is the tree of life who confers eternal life on those whom He saved by His cross. Ephrem writes in the Hymns on the Church XLIX, 16: "The Tree of Life is the symbol Of the Son of the Living One."[71]

Jacob of Sarug also makes a point in his homily, that Christ is the tree of life that distribute His fruits of life. Christ, the Son of the living God is in the center of Paradise giving His body as the fruit of life and His blood as the medicine of life. The fruit of life was promised from the tree of life, Christ. "The bitter tree of knowledge was abolished by the tree of life which he wanted to spring from Golgotha.

In crucifixion He stretched out His arms like branches, And his fruits withered in the land of the dead, and it conceived life."[72]

The cross through which Christ annulled the fall of Adam prefigures the tree in paradise. By eating the fruit of the tree Adam sinned and he hid among the trees. Christ regained Paradise by His lifting up himself on the tree. "The tree in the Garden of Eden which destroyed us is an

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[70] Van Tongeren, *Exaltation of the Cross: Toward the Origins of the Feast of the Cross and the Meaning of the Cross in Early Medieval Liturgy*, 87.

[71] Karim, *Symbols of the Cross in the Writings of the Early Syriac Fathers*, 44.

[72] Karim, *Symbols of the Cross in the Writings of the Early Syriac Fathers*, 44.

antithetical symbol of the cross which saved us."[73] The wood of the tree in paradise caused death and the wood of the cross caused life. The Cross is considered as a fragrant and radiant tree that bears the fruit, Christ. Christ has triumphed on the cross, this victory focuses on the fall: through redemption on the cross, he eradicated the fall caused by Adam. "Christ has subdued death on the cross and from His death on the cross life has come forth; death on the cross was a death unto life."[74] St. Ephrem in his Nisibene Hymns XIV writes as follows

"To the first wood which became a murderer
To it, grace brought forth a Son.
O Cross offspring of the wood,
That didst fight against his sire!
The wood became the fount of death;
The cross became the fount of life."[75]

In this hymn, Ephrem considers the cross as the fruit of the wood which is the tree of knowledge in the Garden of Eden. When the first wood became the cause of death the second wood became the cause of life.

6.4 The Holy Cross Symbolizes the Rod of Moses

The author of the book of Numbers describes the incident of bronze serpent in chapter 21, (Num: 21:4-9). The Lord sent poisonous serpents to punish the Israelites when they spoke against Him and Moses. When they repented, Moses prayed to the Lord for protection from the poisonous snakes. Moses erected a bronze serpent and those who looked at it were saved. The Syriac Fathers portray Moses as the chief of the Prophets and the leader of the old disciples. According to the Syriac Fathers, Moses' life is a type of the cross and devoted to the cross. It is not only the actions of Moses, that point to the cross, but his whole career and life as a savior and leader to Israelites, his life and books, reveal the cross. In order to bring out the strong relationship between Moses and the cross, the Syriac Fathers show the significant role of the rod of Moses. The function of the books of Moses, then, was to disclose the mission of the cross. They attribute

[73] Kaniarakath, "Through Stauros to Doxa: A Biblical Understanding of the Cross," 2.

[74] Van Tongeren, *Exaltation of the Cross: Toward the Origins of the Feast of the Cross and the Meaning of the Cross in Early Medieval Liturgy*, 245.

[75] Karim, *Symbols of the Cross in the Writings of the Early Syriac Fathers*, 39.

the power of Moses to his rod which was a type of cross. It is the power of the cross that worked out through the staff of Moses when the waters of the Red Sea were divided to deliver the Israelites, and when the Amalekites were defeated. The Syriac Fathers find a lifelong presence of the rod with Moses as a lasting relationship between Christ and Moses.[76]

"Come to the rod of Moses, the Prophet of the Hebrews,
And see how the mystery of the crucified man is painted in it.
The creator did great miracles through the rod of the righteous,
Which was carrying the mystery of the wood of crucifixion."[77]

One of the reasons for the Syriac Fathers to consider Moses' rod a type of cross was that both of them were made of wood. With the rod of Moses, he performed many miracles. He changed the nature of the water from bitter to sweet, he gave them water from the rock, he divided the sea into two etc. "In the sermons of *Hebdomadam sanctum* I, 338 Ephrem considers the staff of Moses to be a type of the cross because the staff protected the nations, and likewise, the cross also spread its wings in the Churches protecting those who believe in it."[78]

CHAPTER SEVEN

7. The Christological Significance of the Holy Cross

The symbol cross has existed in various forms in different cultures from ancient time. But as a Christian symbol, the cross transcends all the previous symbolic understanding. It is by Jesus Christ' death and resurrection that the cross became a powerful Christian symbol and object. "For the early Christians, the cross was more a symbol of resurrection than a symbol of death. Thus, the cross was always depicted as a victorious sign."[79] It was very important for the early Christians to assert the resurrection symbolism of the cross, as they wanted to assert the fact of Jesus' resurrection.

There is an extensive use of the cross as a symbol and as an object in the Christian liturgy. "The cross is venerated because of Christ, who brought about salvation and liberation on the cross; through Christ's triumph on the cross the cross has become glorious."[80] The Holy Cross becomes

[76] Cf. Karim, *Symbols of the Cross in the Writings of the Early Syriac Fathers*, 69.
[77] Karim, *Symbols of the Cross in the Writings of the Early Syriac Fathers, 69.*
[78] Karim, *Symbols of the Cross in the Writings of the Early Syriac Fathers*, 71.
[79] Maniyattu, "The Theological Significance of the Cross in the East Syrian Liturgy," 87.
[80] Van Tongeren, *Exaltation of the Cross: Toward the Origins of the Feast of the Cross and the Meaning of the*

the source of hope and center of Christian worship. In the Church history, the veneration to the cross was not the result of compassion that was shown to the physical suffering of Jesus Christ but devotion to the cross was shown to emphasize the salvific events of death and resurrection of Jesus Christ.

7.1 The Ecclesial Significance of the Holy Cross

The Holy Cross has an important place in the life of the Church. "From the five wounds of Christ on the cross flow the rivers that water the new Paradise, which is the Church."[81] It is from this source of divine life, the cross, flows the streams of God's salvific grace to the Church in and through the sacraments. As a consequence, the cross stands on behalf of the very person of Jesus Christ who is the source of resurrection and salvation. As the cross stands for the very person of Jesus Christ, in the Oriental tradition, they use only a cross without the image of Jesus Christ. For the Oriental Church, the cross is the symbol of Christ's triumph over sin, Satan and death, the symbol of glory, salvation, harmony or communion with God and man.[82] The salutary gifts that Jesus imparted on the cross are re-enacted in the Eucharist and liturgy of the Church.

The Eucharist is the memorial of Christ's passion, death and resurrection. It binds the members of the Church together and binds them to Christ. "The Eucharist is the continuity of the incarnation and it is the participation in the passion and resurrection of Christ."[83] Liturgy is primarily the commemoration and the celebration of the salvific deeds of God. In and through the liturgy these salvific deeds become an active experience for the faithful. The paschal mystery of Christ is re-enacted in the liturgy so that the faithful who participate in it can receive the fruits of salvation.[84]

"All the elements of the liturgy, then, would have us reproduce in our hearts the likeness of the divine Redeemer through the mystery of the cross, according to the words of the Apostle of the Gentiles, 'With Christ I am nailed to the cross. I live, now not I, but Christ liveth in me'.

Cross in Early Medieval Liturgy, 282.

[81] Cantalamessa, *The Eucharist Our Sanctification*, 46.

[82] Cf. Sophy Rose, "The Cross and Its Ecclesial Implications," in *The Folly of the Cross*, ed. Paulachan P. Kochappilly(Bangalore: Dharmaram, 2000), 103.

[83] John Kudiyiruppil, *Eucharistic Ecclesiology: A Critical Study* (Kottayam: HIRS Publications, 1998), 83.

[84] Cf. Kulapurath, "Liturgy is a Means of Union with God," 106.

7.2 The Holy Cross as the climax of the Christ event

The previous arguments of this chapter give the theological importance on the Holy Cross in Christian understanding. Passion, death and resurrection are the main salvific events from a Christological point of view. These salvific events are very much related to the Holy Cross. Jesus Christ suffering reaches its peak on the cross. Jesus Christ fulfilled his salvific mission on the cross by His death on the cross and he victoriously accomplishes the mission in his resurrection.

Proclamation of the Kingdom of God was Jesus Christ' mission. "The only begotten Son of God became Son of man in order to proclaim and to give to man forgiveness of sins, reconciliation with Him and new life. By his death on the cross and His resurrection from the dead he has come into his kingdom."[85]

"According to Oriental tradition the cross is not a sign of suffering and death but rather the source of eternal life; in other words, the very person of the risen Jesus Christ."[86] In the Oriental tradition, the liturgy is the re-enactment of the divine dispensation of God realized in history through Jesus Christ in the Holy Spirit. In their liturgy, they visibly express and ritually celebrate the whole salvific events. The death of Christ is the indispensable and inevitable gateway to resurrection. Death is the means towards the end resurrection. Therefore, it is to be said that the cross is the principal agent that unites the means and the end respectively the death and resurrection.

The Christ-event reaches its climax on the cross at the death and resurrection of Jesus Christ. The purpose of His death on the cross is expressed explicitly in the Gospel of John in Jesus Christ' own words as 'to draw all men (both men and women) to himself'. Thus, Christ gathers all humanity on the cross or he draws near all men and women on the cross. John understands Jesus Christ cry at death; 'it is finished' (John 19:30) not as a cry of defeat and termination but as a victorious affirmation of what has been done, accomplished and achieved.[87]

The Church is the gathering of all faithful. If the Church is the gathering of the faithful it can be said that the first gathering of the faithful took place at the foot of the cross. In other words, Jesus Christ laid the foundation of the Church on the cross. "That means in the fullness of time God

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[85] Schmemann, *The Eucharist: Sacrament of the Kingdom*, 41.

[86] Rose, "The Cross and Its Ecclesial Implications," 103.

[87] Lewis, *Between Cross and Resurrection: A Theology of Holy Saturday*, 34.

sent His Son to the world in order to gather together or to make an *ecclesia* of the scattered children of God and to redeem them eternally through His death."[88] Who are the faithful those are gathered on the cross? The Gospel of Mark gives the answer to this question. In this Gospel, Jesus says, 'I came not to call the righteous, but sinners' (Mk: 2:17).

In Christian understanding, the cross symbolically represents the profound salvific events of Jesus' death and resurrection. "The cross of Christ thus stands as the unique expression of the self-actualization of Jesus Christ."[89] The struggle between God and the devil is resolved on the cross where Jesus won over the powers of evil and defeated death by his sacrificial death on the cross. It is a glorious battle and the cross is the symbol of victory. Christ conquered death by dying himself on the wood of the cross. During the painful death of Jesus Christ on the cross the veil of the temple of Jerusalem was torn from top to bottom. 'Then Jesus Christ cried again with a loud voice and breathed His last. At that moment, the curtain of the temple was torn in two, from top to bottom' (Mathew 27:50-51). The veil of the temple which divided the sacred and the secular was torn by Jesus Christ death on the cross.

The cross of Christ is the symbol of humanity's repentance before God. Jesus Christ during His earthly mission, preached the Good News, taught the values of the kingdom of heaven and healed the sick. By accepting the cross, he reached the zenith of His mission. Death on the cross gave Jesus Christ a new mode of life and existence.

[88]Rose, "The Cross and Its Ecclesial Implications," 105.
[89] Amarnad, "The Cross and Shepherding of Christ," 74.

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